HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

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SUMMARY OF HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

I. The Formation of Christian Philosophy in the Patristic Age

1. The Doctrinal Contribution of Christianity

Christianity contains revealed truths of the strictly supernatural order as well as some truths of the natural order. These latter are object of philosophical study, such as God and the origin of the world, man and his relations with God. The revelation of these truths makes it easier for more men to know them with certainty, but does not render it useless or unnecessary for these truths to be studied by reason alone. Thus, the Christian already knew by revelation that God exists, that He is transcendent to the world, that man was created to His image and likeness, with a spiritual and immortal soul.

2. Overall View of the Formation of Christian Philosophy

In the beginnings, Christian doctrine was based on the oral preaching of the witnesses of the life of Christ and on Holy Scripture. However, already in the 2nd century it was seen that it was necessary to make use also of theological speculation, both in order to make more precise the dogmatic formulations of the Christian truths as well as to combat heretical teachings.

The principal enemy of Christianity in those times was the Greek GNOSIS, an intellectual movement of the 2nd century which claimed to use the teachings of Jesus, reducing them to the limits of reason and interpreting them in conformity with philosophical schemes of the ancient mythology, thus adulterating the true content of the faith.

From this perspective, the Christian philosopher, rooted in the faith, began a laborious task of purifying philosophy from the many elements coming from Greek culture, bringing it into agreement with the faith and converting it into an instrument to serve the faith. This prevented the adaptation of Christian doctrine to any Greek philosophy and permitted a certain utilization of Greek philosophy on the part of Christian thinkers. In this sense we can establish two historical landmarks: St. Augustine with respect to Neo-Platonism; St. Thomas Aquinas, with respect to Aristotelianism.

At the height of Christian philosophy we find the work of St. Thomas Aquinas, with a body of doctrine based on the natural truths revealed by God, having as its central point the notion of the act of to-be and at the same time constituting a higher synthesis of the truths found in Platonism and in Aristotle's thought. For this reason philosophy, or more properly the metaphysics of St. Thomas Aquinas, represents the reference point in order to evaluate all the previous solutions found in Christian philosophy.

3. The First Fathers of the Church

In theology, the name "Father of the Church" is reserved for the author who meets the following four conditions:

a) orthodoxy of doctrine;

b) holiness of life;

c) antiquity;

d) recognition by the Church.

However, many authors who do not meet all these conditions are included in the study of patristics. The first Christian writers who had to face up to the pagan culture were the Apologists who roundly affirmed the superiority of Christian doctrine over pagan philosophy. We must recognize two basic attitudes, one of criticism and rejection of pagan philosophy as the source of heresies, which is the attitude of Tertullian (150-225) and Tatian (living in 170), the other the attitude of those who tried to purify Greek philosophy so as to convert it into an instrument which could be used in spreading the faith and understanding it. In this second group we have authors such as St. Justin (+165), St. Irenaeus (126-203) and other apologists. With these writers the long and hard task of purifying and bringing together the first philosophical elements begins.

4. The Neo-Platonism of the School of Alexandria and of the Cappadocians

Alexandria was the city of the Hellenic world in which there was the greatest mixture of cultures, beliefs, philosophies, etc. It is the city where Philo (30 B.C. - 40 A.D.) was born and where he taught as one of the founders of Neo-Platonism, which began the allegorical interpretation of the Old Testament using elements of Platonism and Stoicism. A Christian community was flourishing in Alexandria and from this community arose the so-called school of Alexandria, founded by a Christian convert from Stoicism named Pantenos (+200). His teachings were collected by a young Athenian who succeeded him as director of the school, who was Clement of Alexandria (150-215). He considered that God in His Providence had prepared the coming of Jesus Christ with the Old Testament and with Greek philosophy and thus the faith in Jesus Christ has not eliminated philosophy but rather philosophy is useful to the Christian as long as it is used in service of the faith. For Clement philosophy is the handmaid of theology.

The most relevant figure of this school is Origen (185-253), who already at the age of 18 was the leader of the catechism school of Alexandria. He tried to extract everything that seemed useful from all the philosophical systems of his time and uses this in his commentaries on Sacred Scripture. In this way he transmits Platonism and other philosophical concepts to medieval Christianity. He does not always succeed in subordinating philosophy to the faith, however, and at times he falls into very serious errors. Around the year 230, he went to Caesarea in Cappadocia where he founded a school in which, a century or so later, the three Cappadocian Fathers will receive their formation. These Fathers were defenders of the supremacy of the faith over the rationalism of the Arians, who tried to reduce the faith to pure philosophy and used Platonic ideas to show that the Son cannot be of the same essence as the Father, and thus is not God.

St. Gregory Nazianzen states that the essence of God cannot be defined in negative terms, but rather must be defined positively as FULL REALITY. St. Gregory of Nyssa, the brother of St. Basil, offers us a Platonic vision of reality which will have visible influence in the Middle Ages in the West.

If we would want to make a summary of this whole period, we would have to characterize it as the period in which, in one way or another, a Christian outlook on man is formed, influenced by Platonism which will be propagated by various authors, mainly by St. Augustine and by Pseudo-Dionysius, in medieval thought. This current, called Augustinianism, will understand the soul not as the form of the body but rather as a living, rational substance, incorporeal and complete in itself, which makes use of the body in order to reach its end. Some authors distinguish in man a triple reality: the body or SOMA, the soul or PSYKHE , and the spirit or PNEUMA, as if we could speak of a higher soul (the PNEUMA) and the lower soul (PSYKHE). Nevertheless, all the authors stress the unity of man as opposed to any sort of dualism which separates matter and spirit into two stagnant compartments.

5. The Transmission of Greek Philosophy in the Schools of Syria and in the Neo-Platonic Latin Christians

Up to now we have been concerned with the Eastern Fathers, but we must remember that Christianity spread from Palestine in all directions within the Roman Empire. Rome contributed the political and organizational genius, while the Hellenic world supplied the culture and with that the philosophy. It is also well known that the Church did not emerge officially until 313 and that in the meantime Greek thought had taken new directions. In the first years of the Christian era, the speculative force of the Greek philosophies was dying out and these philosophies were being replaced by a notable scepticism. Nevertheless, the swan song of Greek philosophy was launched in Neo-Platonism, born of the union of philosophy with the religion of the Old Testament through the work of Philo of Alexandria and the ex-Christian Ammonius Saccas (175-242).

The principal representative of this movement was the Egyptian Plotinus (205-270). At the age of 50 he wrote the Enneads, in which he teaches, among other things, that the nature of things is explained by their proceeding from the One by way of necessary emanation, since the multiple is based necessarily on unity. Well now, since God comes before all things, we cannot call Him essence or being, but rather One. In other words, the One (God) is the most radical reality, and therefore is more than being, more than essence, more than existence. Beginning with the One, reality appears by division. Nevertheless, having arrived at this point Plotinus affirms that something, in the measure in which it participates in the intelligible, is real and good, and is not real and good in the measure in which it is corporeal and material. Matter is of itself non-being and evil, as the extreme opposite of the absolute and the One. With this metaphysical basis, his disciple Porphyry (232-304) will begin a Neo-Platonic interpretation of the works of Plato and Aristotle which will very soon remodel the Greek philosophical patrimony.

All of this was what the Christian philosophers were faced with from the beginning of the 3rd century, both in the East and in the West. We have already taken a glance at the Eastern Fathers but before mentioning those of the West, it must be pointed out that when the Byzantine Empire fell into decay, this Greek cultural patrimony passes to Antioch and Edessa, and from there to the Arabs, as we shall see later.

The Latin Fathers were less interested in speculation than in moral topics. For this reason the spreading of a Christian Platonism in the West was much slower. In St. Hilary of Poitiers (315-359) we shall find a short philosophical explanation about God. He says that God is THE VERY ONE WHO IS, that is to say, there is nothing more proper to God than being. Hence, God is pure Being, immutable and eternal and all divine attributes are deduced from ESSE. St. Thomas Aquinas will follow him in this point. Nevertheless, St. Hilary afterwards identifies

being with the immutable and the unbegotten, as Plato had done centuries earlier, and this will influence St. Augustine.

St. Ambrose of Milan (333-397) studied Philo and Origen very amply, but he did not develop any metaphysical speculation about God. The little bit that he says is that God is He Who Is, that is, that He always exists. In this way, he unites the notion of being with that of eternity. Perhaps for this reason he affirms that the word which best suits God is OUSIA or ESSENTIA, which agrees with the Platonic doctrine, but also supposes identifying the notion of being with that of essence, thus "essentializing" the notion of being, which will also have much influence in later thought

With respect to cosmology, Platonic influence comes through authors who were not very original, such as the pagan Macrobius at the end of the 3rd century, a declared disciple of Plato and Plotinus. More useful was the translation into Latin of the Enneads of Plotinus by Marius Victor (+363), since that permitted the use of the Neo-Platonic notion of God, as the One previous to Being and substance, in order to combat some Arian objections.

6. Balance

To end this very brief exposition of some of the philosophical elements of the Father, let us point out that the Fathers are fundamentally theologians, not philosophers. Necessity led them to make use of philosophy in an exclusively instrumental way, discriminating its truths and errors with respect to the Faith, so that it is dangerous and erroneous to forget that when the Fathers use certain philosophical terms in their works, they are replacing their original meaning with a new religious meaning, born under the light of the divine revelation which they are serving. What has been said up to now is the basis and the conditions in which the intellectual process and the great work of St. Augustine is developed.

SUMMARY OF HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

II. The Philosophical Neo-Platonism of St. Augustine

1. Introduction: Role, Life and Philosophical Formation

If St. Justin and Clement of Alexandria are the first ones to hold a positive attitude with regard to philosophy, St. Augustine is the one who overcomes any hesitation, so that with him the foundations of Christian philosophy are established. The lines of force of St. Augustine's thought arise from the experience of his own life. He was born in Tagaste, in northern Africa, in 350 of a pagan father and a Christian mother (St. Monica). After his early education in that city, he studied rhetoric in Carthage in 370 and three years later he read Cicero's "Hortensia" which aroused in him the passion of reaching the possession of truth. He now read the Holy Scripture but he didn't understand it and he gave it a Manichaean interpretation. (He had never been baptised). Manichaeanism states that we must reject the Old Testament because it teaches an anthropomorphic notion about God. Manichaeanism teaches that there are two principles of reality, that of good or light, which is God, and that of evil or darkness, and the two struggle between themselves for the mastery of this world.

This gave St. Augustine a satisfactory explanation for the existence of evil in the world and in his life. Since it was necessary to read the Latin and Greek classics in order to be a good teacher

of rhetoric, little by little Augustine was improving his philosophical formation, which led him to abandon his Manichaeanism and his hostility to Christianity, but he nevertheless fell into a type of despair about ever being able to reach the truth. In this state of mind he went to Rome in 383 and from there he obtained the municipal chair of rhetoric in Milan. His reading of the translation of Plotinus' "Enneads" strongly impressed him and led him out of scepticism. He rapidly assimilated Neo-Platonism in the conditions of that epoch.

Enthused by the light of the intellect, he began a reform of his customs at the same time in which he found Christianity. Attracted by the fame of St. Ambrose, he went to listen to his sermons, but this of course also meant listening to the content of his sermons, and in them he found the Catholic interpretation of the Old Testament. Of course, he also learned the letters of St. Paul and his teachings about grace. Augustine was baptized on Holy Saturday of the year 387. The greater part of his philosophical works were written in the time between his catechumenate and his priestly ordination, from 385 to 391. Four years after his priestly ordination, he became Bishop of Hippo. From now on, his works are predominantly theological, but many philosophical elements appear in these works. St. Augustine died in the year 430 in Hippo due to an illness while the siege of Hippo by the Vandals was in progress.

The immense work of St. Augustine is on the one hand a collecting, assimilating and transmitting of the Greco-Roman and the Judeo-Christian cultures and on the other hand he marks a new route of thought on explaining in depth the relations between faith and reason which will be taken up, perfected and completed by St. Thomas Aquinas 8 centuries later.

2. The Augustinian Philosophy as Itinerary towards God and Happiness

a) HAPPINESS AND TRUTH. The thought of St. Augustine is always related to his own life. His reading of "Hortensius" awakens in him the great passion to possess the truth and he is also intranquil about the experience of evil. These two currents combine in what will be his favourite topic: THE SEARCH FOR THE TRUTH. For Augustine happiness and the knowledge of the truth are the same thing. Everyone wants to be happy. How do we find happiness? We have to know what to look for and who is looking for it.

The first must be something of such nature that it satisfies all desires and gives peace; with regard to the second, one must know oneself in order to know what is better and how to be good. Those who don't want to be happy are already very unfortunate persons, but not all those who want to be happy achieve this end. We must ascertain what we must desire in order to be happy. Augustine states that the object of our desire must be something permanent and independent of chance or fortune and must exclude anything contingent, for if we love what can perish we always have the fear of losing it. Since only God fulfils all these conditions, since He only is eternal, He will be Happiness Itself and hence the desire for God is the only way to happiness.

Nevertheless, this desire for God is not sufficient. One must also live an upright life, for the real possession of the good desired is a condition for happiness. Since happiness in this world is rooted basically in the human spirit, it will be Wisdom which will teach the full measure in which virtue must be practised. In fact, Wisdom corrects the causes of our miseries, lust, ambition, pride, etc., in which immoderate men believe that they will obtain joy. Here St. Augustine bases his arguments on Holy Scripture in order to tell us what wisdom is, namely, the Wisdom of God and more concretely, the Son of God is the Wisdom of God because He is God. Thus, whoever possesses God, possesses wisdom and hence also happiness.

Along another way St. Augustine arrives to identical conclusions. Since man is composed of body and soul, that which is of lower condition (matter, animal, etc.) does not have the sufficient capacity to make him happy. Since the soul is higher than the body, the cause of man's happiness is only to be found in a spiritual good, that is, virtue. From where does Wisdom which makes virtue possible come to man? From the soul itself it can't come, because that is precisely what is lacking in the soul, as is evident from its desire for happiness. Consequently, the good which is desired is not of human order and cannot be anything else but God.

Happiness is the possession of God, the Highest Good and Immutable Truth. Therefore, the authentic philosopher is truly happy, that is to say, the Christian, who is the only one who can achieve the possession of the Truth in a complete way. Thus, Christianity is the SACROSANCTA PHILOSOPHIA (the most holy philosophy). This conclusion imposes the study of the relations between supernatural faith and human reason, a task which St. Augustine carries out on the basis of his own spiritual experience.

b) FAITH AND REASON. For St. Augustine, the act of faith is not something strange or anti-natural in man, since of all creatures only the one endowed with reason can believe. In fact, all of man's knowledge, of whatever kind it may be, proceeds either from what he has seen himself or what he believes from others. With this approach, the solution for the problem of relations between reason and faith requires a clarification of the terminology that St. Augustine uses. For him every man has a spirit (MENS) whose discursive activity is called RATIO, and its beginning and result - INTELLECTUS - is the comprehension or understanding of the things. Thus RATIO, or reasoning, is in a certain way prior to understanding and all to the act of faith.

For St. Augustine, the despising of reason is the despising of the image of God in us. It belongs to RATIO to show the credibility of Christianity, to acquire a certain comprehension of the faith and to show that there is nothing more reasonable than to believe. INTELLIGE UT CREDAS, or: understand so that you may believe. Once supernatural faith has moved one to have faith, faith awakens the desire of knowing and understanding better what is believed. St. Augustine says: CREDE UT INTELLIGAS (believe so that you may understand) and St. Anselm, his 12th-century disciple, will say FIDES QUAERENS INTELLECTUM (faith seeking understanding).

In both cases it is a question of the faith which is seeking understanding, and from this arises a positive attitude about philosophical activity as an instrument for theological knowledge or discourse. In St. Augustine nothing escapes this programme of CREDO UT INTELLIGAM (I believe so that I may understand). Therefore, faith and reason are two ways of knowing which must collaborate closely in the search for truth. Certainly St. Augustine distinguishes between the Truth and the truths, but to attain them belongs to the same effort. He thinks, along with St. Justin, that any truth, whatever it may be, always pertains to God and consequently is a good proper to Christianity. RATIO, or reason, has a function to perform before the act of faith, but its authentic function and best service is exercised when it discourses in the higher sphere of faith, giving rise to theology. St. Augustine will give a good proof for this on tracing the itinerary of the soul towards God.

c) THE KNOWLEDGE OF GOD. For St. Augustine the knowledge that God exists is universal and natural; Revelation is not indispensable for that knowledge as is proven by the fact

that pagan philosophers have arrived at that knowledge. Therefore, not to know that God exists is culpable ignorance, the fruit of evil passions and of the influence of a bad will. Although the nature of God cannot be known in itself, His existence is easily recognized by those of clean heart, upright reason and good moral disposition. Before proposing rational demonstrations of this to the hard of heart, it is necessary to lead them to the faith. In St. Augustine, good conduct will always be the door which leads to the right use of reason and therefore to faith. Well now, the believer who knows that God exists cannot be dispensed from demonstrating His existence with rational arguments, for that would be the same as despising reason, and therefore despising God, precisely in the name of faith.

First of all, the arguments of the sceptics about the truth must be discarded, for when we experience doubt, we are aware that we think, and therefore we have arrived at the truth with full certainty (the COGITO of St. Augustine is not a starting point for knowledge, as it is in Descartes, but rather only an irrefutable argument against scepticism). St. Augustine argues thus: there are beings which have neither life nor knowledge, like the minerals; other beings have life, like the plants, still others have life and knowledge. If we are attentive, we see that we know only those which we have experienced and those which we can imagine, based on what we have experienced. Well now, our knowledge is composed of the exercise of the EXTERNAL SENSES, which have as their object what is material, and of the exercise of the INTERNAL SENSES, which inform from the corporal sensations, and of the exercise of REASON.

What proceeds from the external senses is fleeting, because their impressions disappear rapidly. If at any rate we desire to know, the internal sense must judge and order the external senses to repeat the observation. In an analogous way reason acts with respect to the internal senses for the same motives: the impressions of the internal or external senses have little reality or being, and short duration. Nevertheless, in reason there appear necessary and immutable realities, such as that of $7 + 3 = 10$. This truth is not found in sense experience, but is imposed on reason by its own evidence. Is there anything higher than reason? There must necessarily exist a higher reality, because reason possesses realities, that is, immutable and necessary truths, but reason itself is contingent, that is, man changes and perishes. Therefore, there is something that transcends man and which has to be the purely intelligible, necessary, immutable and therefore eternal truth, which we call God.

All the arguments which St. Augustine presents in order to arrive to God are reduced in practice to one single proof, the itinerary of which is to pass from the exterior to the interior (the soul) and from the interior world to ascend to the higher (God). This second step is based on the fact that much of man's knowledge is immutable and superior to man himself, and consequently demands something that does not change: the intelligible, necessary, immutable and therefore eternal truth, which is God.

d) DIVINE NAMES. Initially, for St. Augustine, God is understood, rather than as Pure Act or cause of being, as That Being which is always the same or ESSENTIA PLENA (Full Essence), before which everything else is radically contingent. In this sense, Sacred Scripture supplies him with the name which is best applicable to God; EGO SUM QUI SUM (I am who am), or QUI EST (He Who Is), which is conceived by St. Augustine as the existence of That Being

which remains always identical to itself. To affirm that God is He Who Is signifies that He is the Being of the full and supreme essence, the Supreme, Immutable and Eternal Being. Therefore, to prove His existence is the same as showing that what is mutable requires an Immutable from which it depends by participation. That is to say, the imperfect is explained by the Perfect, of which it is the trace and image.

In depth, the demonstration of the existence of God starting with the immutability of the truth coincides with the other metaphysical proofs since traces of the cause are found in the effect. Thus, the very existence of truth in the reason indicates to us that man is a reflection and an image of the divine immutability. It is still fitting to make an important observation: the God that is reached with St. Augustine's method is simultaneously transcendent and immanent to the world.

The first because, faced with the Immutable Being that is God, any other being exists only by participation and between the One and the other there is an infinite gap. But He is also immanent to the world and to the soul since His presence is ascertained in each truth that thought considers or verifies in whatever sphere to which it refers (scientific, moral, etc.). St. Augustine says: "the discourse of the mind doesn't create the truth". And he adds: "Don't seek Him outside. Turn into yourself. The truth dwells within man. And if you discover that your own nature is also mutable, transcend yourself," because "whatever the understanding finds of truth is not due to itself". Hence God is like the intelligible Sun in whose light reason finds the truth, and the interior Master who replies from within to the questions of reason: "You are more intimate to my very self than my own intimacy," St. Augustine says to God.

e) CONCLUSION. The metaphysical stance of St. Augustine transcends his corrective work on Platonism, which has not always been noticed by his followers. Plato did not know the notion of being as act, and thus he moved in the sphere of the essence, of that which makes something be what it is. To speak of essence is to refer to an existent reality, but by concentrating not on the act of being, but rather on being something. In this perspective God is, in fact, highest reality or "full essence" for some Fathers, equivalent to the "ocean of reality" of St. Gregory Nazianzen. St. Anselm of Canterbury and St. Bonaventure, to name some authors who belong to what would later be called the Augustinian tradition, depend on this notion of God as "full essence" in order to demonstrate His existence.

Moreover, they will think as a consequence, in opposition to St. Augustine, that the knowledge of God's existence is immediate, because they will begin from this notion of God that will demand His existence. They will say that since God is "full essence", He must exist. That Being which is the fullness of reality cannot not exist. But St. Augustine always remained faithful to his definition of God as QUI EST (He Who Is), the centre and root of all that is real. Certainly, in order to prove the existence of God, St. Augustine does not begin with the question about why things exist or who has caused them, but that underlies his whole exposition, in such a way that God above all is Being, the cause of every being by participation, and in order to explain the nature of the things he starts off from the notion that God is the Being of the full essence.

3. Creation, Exemplarism and Seminal Reasons

In its most summarized form, the metaphysical elements of St. Augustine's doctrine on creation are the following:

a) God created all things simultaneously out of nothing.

b) All beings have matter. He distinguishes between "spiritual matter" which is proper to the angels and simple matter proper to the beings which are not spiritual. Before receiving the form this matter is absolutely indeterminate, and has some reality, though very precarious before it receives the form. Thus to speak of matter and of change or mutability in beings is to refer to aspects which are intrinsically linked together. By their mutability things show that they have been created by God out of nothing. Hence, between God and the other beings there is a metaphysical abyss which separates the complete self-sufficiency of God and the intrinsic lack of necessity of creatures.

c) Before speaking of the reception of forms in matter, it is necessary to point out that in St. Augustine's vocabulary, "idea", "form", "species" and "RATIO" mean the same thing, the first two being especially indistinct in the whole Augustinian tradition.

For St. Augustine, following Plato, the Ideas are principal forms, the stable or immutable essences of the things, and are eternal since they remain identical to themselves as contained in the intellect of God. All things of this world are found at the same time in the divine Ideas. What remains to be explained is the origin of the Ideas. Since God is the supreme Being, He is at the same time the Highest Intellect and the Immutable Truth. Hence, He knows Himself perfectly and knows Himself in so far as He is and in what He is able to do and in the fullness of His essence He knows that He knows Himself as the exemplary cause or model of whatever can be made if He wants. In effect, since He is the Highest Reality or BEING, He doesn't have to create, but He is free to do so or not. But if He creates, He makes the things to His own likeness, that is, in accordance with the eternal models or Ideas of the things contained in the Word.

The exemplary Ideas, according to St. Augustine, are consubstantial with the Word and participate in His immutability and consequently are eternal.

d) To sum up, creation is the production of things out of nothing, that is, of a matter and a form which reproduce the model or Eternal Idea. In this way, the Ideas are the immutable foundation of the mutable and contingent realities of the sensible world and at the same time the source of the truth and the intelligibility of the things. Thus, the world is a manifestation of God. Each creature is a limited aspect of this manifestation and taken altogether, a poor image, since experience shows that in a certain sense the creation of the world is not finished. In fact, there are beings which are born and then disappear and there are some which still do not exist but

which will come in the future. Nevertheless, it has been said that God created all things simultaneously.

Here, St. Augustine accepts the Stoic doctrine of the "seminal reasons" and says that matter, though very indeterminate, already contains in an incipient way everything that will come to be, so in this sense it can be said that creation is complete. In the very instant of creation, all creatures have been finished.

4. The Creatures.

We are now ready to affirm that, according to St. Augustine, creation is organized in conformity with the model of the divine Ideas. Hence the order, the hierarchy of beings, the beauty, etc. that we find show the degree of likeness of creatures to God. The things that God has brought out of nothing do not receive the being which is proper to God, but rather being according to a more or a less, that is, according to an order and a hierarchy. This inequality arises from the diverse ways of participation in the ESSE SUBSISTENS, which ways are represented by each one of the divine Ideas. To be more specific, the things are likenesses of God according to the way in which they imitate the Ideas. There will be men who are more or less just or wise in the measure in which they participate more or less in the divine Ideas of Justice and Wisdom (which Ideas are consubstantial with the Divine Essence).

But the relations of the things with the Ideas have a source and a model which is the relation of God the Father by which He begets the Word, which reproduces His nature in an absolutely full and perfect manner. By analogy it is the Ideas which permit the creatures to become and to subsist. Thus the things are copies of the Ideas. Therefore in order to ascertain the perfections of the creatures it is necessary to refer back to God. Here St. Augustine shows his own way of being Platonic: God is the Being QUI EST Who presents Himself as the One, the Beauty and the Truth. Since God is the source of all the participated perfections, He confers to creatures being, unity, truth and beauty in diverse degrees. All creatures reflect or are the image of the transcendental properties or perfections of God in a greater or lesser degree, according to a perfectly established hierarchy.

5. Man

The highest of the creatures are the angels, whose existence we know only by faith. We know that they are made of a "spiritual matter", completely and definitively "formed." Due to this material substrate, they are mutable beings, but, because of their contemplation of God, they have remained in a state of immutable happiness. Man is very close in nature to the angel, for man is a spiritual soul which makes use of a body. St. Augustine thinks of man under two aspects: a) man as a complete substance, a composite unity of body and soul; b) man considered philosophically.

In this sense St. Augustine, influenced by Neo-Plationism, does not succeed in explaining the unity and the consequent relations between the body and the soul. For St. Augustine, the soul is a complete rational substance, fitted out so as to be able to govern a body, and which has as its end union with God. If the body in its turn is a complete substance, how do we then explain the unity of man? The topic of the origin of the body was an easy task for St. Augustine, but not

that of the soul. He expressly declares that he doesn't know the concrete way in which God creates the soul, and he makes several conjectures.

On the one hand, he thought in terms of the "seminal reasons", that is, that all souls were created from the beginning in indeterminate matter. On the other hand, he believed in the immediate creation by God of each soul. Finally, his repugnance to admit that something spiritual would arise from matter led him to say that the souls were confided in the beginning to the angels, so that they might infuse them into the bodies at the opportune moment. In either case, we must respect St. Augustine's freedom to say that he does not know. Nevertheless, he knows how to tell us that the rational soul is immortal, because it is indestructible, since it is the seat of the immutable truth and its contrary, error, is not able to destroy it.

Finally, for St. Augustine, since matter - created by God - is good, so also is the human body. In this way faith permits him to overcome the Manichaean dualism. It no longer makes any sense to speak about the body as a prison of the soul, based on the fact that the end of the soul is the beatific vision. If the body does become the prison of the soul, that is due to sin as we shall see later on.

6. Psychology and The Doctrine of Illumination

The metaphysical background of St. Augustine's psychology is constituted by the doctrine of the hierarchy of beings, that is to say, the set of existing beings is arranged perfectly in a hierarchy, at the peak of which is God, followed by the angels, human souls, the other living beings and inanimate beings. God, as the supreme and total reality, has created in such a way that each creature occupies a determined place, and which can influence and cause in lower beings because of its participation or image of God's being. The inverse operation is not possible, because the inferior being lacks sufficient reality to be able to act on the higher being. Hence, the perfect explains the imperfect, both in the reality of the things as well as in knowledge. Well then, the soul which has been made in order to animate the body is whole in the whole body, giving life not only to the complete man, but also to each of his organs and faculties.

For St. Augustine, the soul cannot know anything naturally unless it is through the senses and the higher faculties, that is, there are no innate ideas in the soul. In these conditions, SENSE KNOWLEDGE is described by St. Augustine as follows: when the soul receives, through the senses which it constantly vivifies, a sensation or sense impression, it forms in itself a likeness of the thing and in this likeness knows the corresponding reality. It can't be otherwise for St. Augustine since the object of sense knowledge are the mutable realities and from them true knowledge in the proper sense cannot proceed, that is, the knowledge which is stable and necessary such as $7 + 3 = 10$, that good must be done, or that God exists.

Something analogous occurs with INTELLECTUAL KNOWLEDGE. The soul acquires no knowledge until it discovers it by itself. In fact, in listening to a conversation, we easily skip over many opinions until the speaker states a general or necessary truth and then our assent is produced, that is, the soul recognizes the truth and embraces it. St. Augustine then teaches that although the soul finds in itself the immutable truths, it knows that it is not their source, for it judges by them the results of knowledge and moreover discovers in its need that these truths are something superior.

Well then, the soul finds or recognizes the truth because God is its interior Master, more intimate to it that it is to itself. The soul consults with the Intimate Truth about the knowledge it

acquires and finds the truth in itself. In order to explain the nature of this divine teaching St. Augustine refers to the metaphor of the "light", known as the THEORY OF ILLUMINATION. In order to understand it, we must keep in mind that the act by which thought (the soul) knows the truth is comparable to the way in which the eye sees the bodies. In order to be seen, the things must be illuminated by the sun, even though this star is not directly seen. By analogy, the scientific truths must be intelligible by a certain light, so that they may be understood by the reason. If the sun is the source of light, God is the source of truth.

For St. Augustine, the object of illumination is the truth which God pours into the soul, that is, into our intellect. This light is not supernatural, nor is it a revelation, but rather a natural participation of the intelligible objects or ideas. The doctrine of illumination signifies the knowledge of creatures and of scientific truths, which are "copies", from the Ideas. For God is the intelligible Sun which illumines our intellect and makes it participate in the ideas or intelligible objects. Along this path, St. Augustine affirms the soul as the seat of truth. Since the truth is immutable, the soul itself must be immortal once it has been created. Consequently, the soul is basically spirit or MENS, that is, intelligence or thought. Since the soul cannot expect any help from what is inferior, it can know itself only by a purely interior way.

On the other hand, since it has been created to the image and likeness of God, we can find in it images of the Trinity. Here St. Augustine will begin the illustration of the dogma of the Trinity. For St. Augustine the triad mind, knowledge and love constitute an image of the One and Triune God.

7. Evil and Freedom

The "full Essence" or God is the Good, both for St. Augustine and for Plato. Hence, by creation all reality is good in as far as it is. The perfections of the creatures are only participations of the Good, according to a more or a less. Evil has not been created by God, but it exists. Therefore, it can only consist in the privation of a due perfection, and as privation, in order to exist it is supported in the good as in a subject.

This identification of being with good and the concept of evil as a privation of good (and hence of being or reality) we will find constantly repeated by Christian thinkers, starting with St. Augustine. One usually speaks of many classes of evil, such as physical or natural evils, but the only true evil is moral evil, or sin, which proceeds from the free will of rational creatures. How is this possible? Is the free will evil? St. Augustine's answer is clear: The human will, considered in itself, is good, and free will, in itself, is good and the condition for attaining happiness. But the created will is fallible, it can err, and the exercise of free will brings with it the risk of sin. Thus, free will becomes evil when it is deprived of the DUE ORDER, as St. Augustine expresses in his "Confessions." The rebellion of the body against the soul is the consequence of original sin, from which concupiscence and ignorance proceed. Since then the soul, which had been created in order to govern a body, finds itself ruled by the body and is thus oriented towards the material. And since it takes from itself the sensations and images, it exhausts itself and ends up taking itself to be a body.

St. Augustine's doctrine is no different than the experience of his life. For this reason he traces with strong and vivid lines the drama of evil as he recalls it in his adolescence. He shows how one evil leads to another in his "Confessions" and he also shows how the gravity of the sin has great influence on man's life: the successive falls, the excuses that become justifications, etc. In short, he shows that evil which is not cured grows and builds for itself ways without outlet. Therefore St. Augustine understood the need of grace in order to be able to come out of sin and

to fulfil the Will of God. In fact, Divine Grace restores to the free will the power of doing good. Thus for St. Augustine freedom consists in using well the free will. "LIBERTAS VERA EST CHRISTO SERVIRE" (True freedom is to serve Christ). Hence freedom is greater when man is more united to God and thus is less able to carry out evil. Thus St. Augustine ties in with the theological topic of Grace.

8. The Two Cities

St. Augustine gives us his moral doctrine and that of happiness in his work "De civitate Dei" (The City of God). In man virtue is the condition for happiness, and the ordered will is the condition for virtue, but the free will is raised to the love of God by grace and manifests itself in a multitude of concrete actions which affect a double aspect of the natural sphere: the individual and the social. Since the human body is good, the temporal societies (CIVITAS TERRENA) are destined to achieve the goods needed for life, but there also exists another city (CIVITAS DEI) which is formed by Christians of all nations, the construction of which is what gives meaning to universal history. Men and States are ruled by the will, but by a will that must be ordered and subject to norms.

In other words, every society requires peace, and peace is "the tranquillity of order." But two cities exist, one ordered to the material, the other to the spiritual, which are distinct and even opposed to one another. The two cities are mixed and intermeshed with one another. They are not two types of historical realizations, but opposite principles of personal conduct and of social realities.

The sense of history is that these two cities oppose one another and fight between themselves. Nevertheless, and this is St. Augustine's conclusion, whatever the history of man may be, at the end the CIVITAS TERRENA will perish and the CIVITAS DEI will be victorious in virtue of the love of God.

9. Influence on St. Thomas Aquinas

St. Thomas Aquinas recognizes the indisputable authority of St. Augustine as Doctor of the Faith, but as philosopher, he accepts some of his doctrines and rejects others. Concretely, St. Thomas accepts three important doctrines: the causal transcendentalism or metaphysical abyss which exists between God and the creatures; exemplarism, accepting the doctrine of participation at the apex of his metaphysical thought; and the solution of the problem of evil. Nevertheless, he has serious reservations about other points of St. Augustine's metaphysics, as for example the metaphysical structure of the creature and the doctrine of knowledge. For St. Augustine, the "light" of the intellect is the reception of ideas from God, but for St. Thomas it is the light of the agent intellect by which what is intelligible in material things is abstracted or grasped. All of this is related with the doctrine of hylomorphism which we shall see later.

10. St. Augustine and Augustinianism

We can consider two principal sources in St. Augustine's philosophical work. On the one hand, Neo-Platonism and on the other hand, Revelation. St. Augustine does an analogous work with Neo-Platonism to what St. Thomas Aquinas will do centuries later with Aristotle. He christianizes it, that is, he converts an emanationist doctrine into a creationist doctrine. In this task we find the original lines of his thought, which can be synthesized thus:

a) there is no true philosophy unless man adheres to the supernatural order, which frees man's will from concupiscence through grace and safeguards thought from scepticism through the certainty that comes from Revelation, the source of light;

b) between two solutions of the same problem, one must grant more importance to the one which explains things through God, than through nature and man (the inferior is understood better and is justified by the superior);

c) one cannot separate the life of thought from practical conduct. Thus the true philosophy not only provides the end, but also the means;

d) every intellectual itinerary must begin from the principle of the interiority of thought, that is to say, the soul is the seat of truth.

This is not the complete formulation of St. Augustine's doctrine but it is a correct expression of its spirit and constitutes the framework of the whole Augustinian tradition, which will exercise an enormous influence throughout the ages, even to our time. Till the 12th century, St. Augustine will be the great source, if not to say the only important one, of medieval thought. Augustinianism is renewed, by opposition to the stands which abuse logic, in the schools of St. Victor of Chartres (12th century) and has influence on all the directions of thought, both in the mystical thought of St. Bernard as well as in the metaphysics of St. Anselm of Canterbury, in the voluntarism which comes to Duns Scotus and in the contemplative philosophy of St. Bonaventure, in the Thomism and in the Franciscanism which claim for themselves fidelity to St. Augustine, though in both of them it coexists with Aristotelianism.

SUMMARY OF HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

III. The Patristic after St. Augustine

After St. Augustine and till the beginning of the 9th century, there are no creative philosophers in the East or in the West, but only authors who systematize the previous thought. One must keep in mind that during this time Europe suffered invasions from the Eastern peoples from the 5th century onwards and the East was invaded by Islam from the 7th century, and this rendered the diffusion of culture very difficult. However, these summarizing writers became fundamental links in the transmission of philosophy in such a way that they can be considered in all truth as the remote founders of the medieval philosophical systems.

1. Boëthius

He was born in Rome in 470 and died by execution in Pavia in 525, where he receives local cult with Church approval. He commented and translated Greek philosophy and transmitted it to the Latin world. His translations of Aristotle and of Porphyry and his treatises on logic will make him an indisputable master of this material till the 12th century. His influence will also extend for centuries to the method of intellectual work - the commentary of a text -, to the way of condensing thought into precise formulae - the sentences - and in particular, his classification of theoretical sciences. As philosopher, his main work is "De consolatione philosophiae" which teaches that philosophy is a concrete reality consisting in loving and seeking wisdom, which is the same as loving and seeking God.

a) Hierarchy or Classification of the Sciences

To love and seek God requires some beings who know and some acts to be practised. Thus Boëthius distinguishes between theoretical philosophy and practical philosophy. The first admits as many divisions as there are types of beings which are known. They include the INTELLECTIBILIA, the beings which exist without matter - this division is called theology -, the INTELLIGIBILIA, which are the souls in matter - this division is called psychology - and the NATURALIA, the sciences of nature - this division is called by Boëthius physiology. This last division includes the so-called QUADRIVIUM, or arithmetic, astronomy, geometry and music. He adds to this classification also the TRIVIUM, or grammar, rhetoric and logic, which are necessary not in order to know, but rather for the correct expression of knowledge. Here Boëthius also posits the problem about the nature of the general ideas or universals.

b) The Universals

Porphyry (232-304) in his "Isagoge" asked some questions about the nature of general notions or ideas, as for example, whether the genera and species exist in themselves or only in the mind, and if in themselves, whether they are corporeal or incorporeal, and if the latter, whether they exist united to the things only, or also separated from the things. Boëthius, in his two commentaries on "Isagoge" denies two extremes, namely that the universals are simply fabricated by the mind and that they are corporeal realities or substances. Thus, universals are incorporeal because as universals they exist only in the intellect which abstracts them from the many material things. Boëthius concludes that they subsist united to the sensible, but are conceived by transcending what is corporeal. He recognizes that this solution is Aristotelian, but he doesn't make it his own and agrees with Plato in saying that a reality corresponds to the universals, the reality of the IDEA. Perhaps for this reason he omits in his commentary on the "Isagoge" this idea of Aristotle.

c) God

God is the most excellent "intellectible." Therefore the highest science deals with God. In his "De consolatione philosophiae" he makes a sketch of natural theology. God is the highest Good, the perfect Being so that none greater than He can be thought. To show His existence, he uses the principle which states that the imperfect in its genus is always a diminution of the perfect. Since there is obviously imperfection, the perfect being also exists, which is God. Since He is perfect, God is the Goodness and the Happiness. Boëthius defines happiness as "the perfect state in which all goods are possessed." St. Thomas will later make this phrase a classic. Since God is perfect He is not only happy, but Happiness Itself. Thus man's happiness is attained by participating in the Divine Happiness. God's transcendence makes Him escape the categories and the determinations of the intellect. We know that God is the First Cause of the world. With respect to Himself, we only know that God, being perfect, is "by Himself everything that He is."

d) The Souls, Freedom and Providence

Human souls are "intellectibles" which degenerate to "intelligibles" by their contact with the body. They pre-existed with the angels but once they have fallen into the bodies, they can reach happiness by applying reason to the "intellectibles." For Boëthius, the natural beings tend by nature to their natural places and man is no exception. He tends to God but he must do so with his will. For this end he is endowed with reason and is capable of knowing and choosing. Man will thus be freer and happier the more he agrees through rational knowledge with the Will of God. Here the way of reconciling human freedom with Divine Providence is brought up. If God knows what man is going to do and at the same time governs the world by Providence, how can we explain human freedom? If man is free, is God's Providence infallible?

For Boëthius this approach is inexact, for they are two distinct matters, since the foreseeing of human acts by God is realized in eternity, whereas man's exercise of freedom is realized in time, in which there is a before and an after. God is eternal and he defines eternity as "perfect and simultaneously complete possession of an interminable life." God lives and knows in a continuous present, and thus He sees eternally the necessary as necessary and the free as free. By contemplating the totality of the world, Boëthius understands Divine Providence as the order of things considered in the knowledge of God. Boëthius understands destiny as the interior law of the world. They are two distinct realities, one eternal, the other temporal, though destiny is nothing else than the temporal realizations of the decrees of Providence. Therefore, one does not oppose Providence but rather serves it. Consequently it also does not destroy human freedom.

e) Metaphysical Structure of Natural Beings

In "De hebdomadibus" Boëthius brings up the metaphysical structure of natural beings when, following Plato and St. Augustine he identifies being with good and non-being with evil, so that every being, in so far as it is, is substantially good. In these conditions it becomes necessary to distinguish between any being God Who is Being in Itself. God is perfectly simple and He has no parts, but in the creatures there is diversity between the "being" and the "whatness". The creature is composed of determining elements and determined elements, but none of these parts is the whole, as we find for example in the case of man who is composed of soul and body, neither of which is the whole man.

To sum up, the form is the determining element of the composite and Boëthius designates this as "esse" or "quo est" and this is what gives being. Therefore the formula given above about the diversity of being and of that which is establishes the distinction between the form and the whole (substance), but not between the co-principles of essence and esse. Boëthius in this way had a glimpse at the distinction of esse and essence, which is of key importance in St. Thomas, but he didn't gain anything from it. He rather came to identify the esse of the creature with its form. For Boëthius, God is distinguished from the creatures by the fact that in His perfect simplicity His Esse and His Whatness are the same thing, which does not occur in creatures.

2. Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite

An unknown author writing in Greek about the end of the 5th or the beginning of the 6th century wrote a number of works which constitute one of the principal sources of medieval thought on central topics such as the divine attributes, the angels, evil, the transcendentals, the degrees of being.

On the one hand his work signifies a Christianization of Neo-Platonism, correcting works of Plotinus and Porphyry, though using their terminology. For example, evil is a privation, therefore matter is good because is was created by God.

The influence of this writer began to make its influence felt in Constantinople in 532 and it would be admired by Nicholas of Cusa in 1464. This extraordinary influence was due to a confusion which lasted till the 15th century. The author of the "Corpus Areopagiticum", which work had the signature "Dionysius", presents himself as a disciple of St. Paul who transmits a doctrine for "the Apostles to their disciples, that is, for those already initiated into Christianity. His testimony will be accepted by St. Maximus and from then on the author will be identified as the convert at the Areopagus who is mentioned in the Acts of the Apostles, XVII, 34.

a) The Knowledge of God

Pseudo-Dionysius (PsD) presents his work as a meditation on Scriptures. God is absolutely transcendent and so one must not try to verify rationally His ineffable nature. Only God knows Himself, but He has revealed Himself to man in Scriptures, giving Himself various names which simple people accept in all simplicity. Whoever wishes to have a clear idea of God must grasp the content of these names and see how they can be applied to God. We must affirm about God the names given by Scripture (Love, Goodness, Life, Being, etc.), (affirmative theology) but at the same time deny them, for none of them expresses God adequately (negative theology). Both attitudes are reconciled in a third, which consists in saying that God deserves each of these names in a way which is ineffable, for God is "hyper-being", "hyper-love", etc. (superlative theology). PsD inaugurates a method which will have much historical importance: to deny in God all things as they exist in the reality known by man.

b) The Hierarchy of Beings

PsD, a Christian with Platonic education, identifies God the Creator with the Good. This is the name which best designates the cause of all beings. The Good spreads its rays through all creatures (like the sun does), giving to each of them its corresponding degree of being and fixing each in its proper nature and relations towards other creatures. Thus, the higher beings have influence over the lower beings and since the universe is disposed in degrees, a "metaphysical continuity" prevails in creation. St. Thomas will accept this harmonic vision of the degrees of created being, as well as the principle that the good spreads itself (BONUM DIFFUSIVUM SUI) as applied to the free generosity of God's creative act and to the constant influence of higher creatures upon the lower. Hence, the world with its variety is a revelation of God and of His perfections. Inversely, all beings and their perfections are contained supereminently in God, and hence God is the Being of all things in the sense that He is the cause of the being of the things.

Once we understand how PsD links divine transcendence with the participation of creatures in descending degrees in order to give a basis for the hierarchy of beings, it is fitting to point out that if being and good are identified, at once the question of evil crops up. For PsD, evil is nothing other than privation, non-being, apparent reality, which God permits in the order of greater goods. Deep down, it is the same concept as that of St. Augustine. Both of them will have influence in the Middle Ages, and especially on St. Thomas.

c) God in Himself

If God is the Good in as much as He distributes goods, in Himself His most appropriate name, according to Scriptures, is that of Being, "He Who Is", and thus cause of every creature. But in the strict sense God is not Being. If we consider God from the viewpoint of creation, evidently He is Being and the cause of all beings, but considered in Himself, He should have another name, the One. Indeed the One contains everything in a pure unity which is exempt from multiplicity. The multiple cannot exist without the One, but the One can exist without the multiple. Everything which is participates in the One, and He participates in nothing.

This preference for the name of the One is due to the strong Neo-Platonic influence received by PsD. We have already arrived at the predominant mystical idea of PsD: the One also does not properly designate God. In reality, God has no name, nor is He anything of that which is, nor of that which is not (negative theology). He transcends all being and all knowledge. Whoever understands this has reached mystical ignorance and the highest degree of knowledge.

d) Balance

The "Corpus Areopagiticum" enjoyed great prestige for the reasons already mentioned and became one of the fundamental books of study in the Middle Ages and will be interpreted by such diverse authors as Hugh of St. Victor, St. Albert the Great. St. Bonaventure, Meister Eckhart, etc.

The extraordinary influence of PsD is exercised over the main topics of metaphysics: the divine attributes, the angels, evil, the transcendentals, the degrees of being, and many others. St. Thomas Aquinas quotes him more than 1500 times and owes him, among other things, his theology of the angels and especially the notion of being as an act which is possessed by God with infinite and total intensity, whereas in creatures it has diverse degrees of limited intensity.

3. John Philoponus, Christian Commentator of Aristotle

John Philoponus is an exception to the Neo-Platonists in the later Eastern Patristic period. He lived in the first half of the 6th century and commented on Aristotle, raising questions which St. Thomas Aquinas would answer later. Of special importance is his commentary on "De Anima", which is an excellent summary about the ideas regarding the nature of the agent intellect. Some identify this with God, others with some demiurge while others think that man has two intellects, one passive, the other active. He says that these last ones have read Aristotle with Platonic mentality. He says that his own interpretation is the true one and the only one possible for a Christian; namely, that man has one intellect which is sometimes in act (agent) and sometimes in potency (passive). This solution also permits the demonstration of the immortality of the soul. John Ph. was read by the first Arabian theologians and had great influence on them, and St.

Thomas was also grateful for some commentaries on "De Anima" which confirmed his own interpretation of Aristotle.

4. St. Maximus the Confessor, Commentator of Dionysius

Maximus of Chrysopolis (580-662) is closely linked to the long Christological controversies of his century (monothelism). He was educated in Neo-Platonism, wrote extensively in various fields of theology though only one work, not an original one, would have a great influence in medieval thought. Imbued in the doctrine of PsD, it is surprising that he interprets him in his own way. In several points, the influence of PsD is exercised mainly through the interpretation of Maximus. In fact, the high Middle Ages will make no distinction between the work of the one and the interpretation of the others. John Scotus Eriugena translates his main work under the name of the "Ambiguous" and converts its content in the framework of his own metaphysical, moral and mystical doctrine which will leave a profound trace on the Middle Ages.

5. St. John Damascene (+749)

St. John Damascene (675-749) belonged to a well-to-do Christian family which was working in the court of the Arab dynasty of the Omeyas. He is considered as the last of the Eastern Fathers. In him there coincides the circumstance of belonging culturally to the Byzantine world while living within the territories governed by the Arabs. His principal work, "Sources of Knowledge" is a very personal summary of the teachings of the Greek Fathers. It is divided into three parts. It was translated into Latin in the 12th century, serving as a model for the "Book of Sentences" of Peter Lombard.

a) Natural Theology

One idea which the high Middle Ages owes to St. John D. - to approve it or to dispute it - is that there is no man who does not know that God exists. To know that He exists, it suffices to contemplate the order and the conservation of creatures and to pay attention to the Revelation of the Old and the New Testaments. For John D., it is natural that man knows spontaneously that God exists, but he points out that the malice of Satan and the effects of sin darken the heart of man, at times up to the point of not knowing of God's existence. For this reason we must make use of rational arguments to establish this truth. Making use of the Pauline principle that God can be known from the creatures, he develops three demonstrations, by way of the mutability of beings which necessarily demands the existence of an uncreated creator, by way of the conservation and governing of things, and by way of the order in the world, which is not a fruit of chance.

b) The Nature of God

On the other hand, he vigorously stresses the transcendence of God. Only God knows Himself fully. Though we can know His existence, we cannot know in depth His nature which is incomprehensible. When we affirm that God has no limitations, by saying that He is infinite, incorporeal, immutable, etc., we are only expressing what He is not, and when we apply to Him the positive attributes like one, good, just, etc., we are also not expressing adequately the divine essence, but we are only affirming something that befits His nature, but which is infinitely richer. So the divine declaration of Exodus 3, 14: "I am He who is" expresses above all the incomprehensibility of God on the part of man. God is beyond being and knowledge. Therefore that expression of Scripture signifies, for John D., that God possesses and unites in Himself the totality of being like an ocean of reality (OUSIA) which is infinite and unlimited. This formula will be commented many times in the Middle Ages, especially by St. Thomas.

c) Influence

During the life of John D., probably most of his works were translated into Arabic. In the West, the first translation of "Source of Knowledge" dates from 1150. In spite of this late entry, this work will spread quickly in all Scholastic thought, precisely because it contains so much that agrees with it, such as its structure, its precision and its Aristotelian content.

6. The Culture Handed Down by the Fathers

Medieval philosophy is an exclusively Western phenomenon, and its immediate precedents are found in Latin culture. more exactly in the Christianized classical Latin culture. The majority of the Fathers had been educated in conformity with the cultural ideal proposed by Cicero and Quintillian, the first of whom deplored the separation of wisdom from eloquence, saying that the philosophers, on not knowing how to speak, and the rhetoricians, on not knowing how to think, stun our ears. Thus it becomes necessary to educate the youth to form them to be learned orators who would be able to govern society correctly.

On the other hand Quintillian, due to the influence of Seneca and the Stoics, proposes the formation of honourable men who know how to speak. In conformity with the penetration of Christianity into the teaching structure, a change of meaning will be given to Quintillian's ideal, namely the eloquence will now be Christian. In this Christian eloquence the wisdom of the faith replaces the pagan philosophy. The sciences and the liberal arts are not rejected, but now they are placed at the service of the comprehension and exposition of the Holy Scriptures. This will be the educational programme which will last until the 12th century.

SUMMARY OF HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

IV. The First Scholastics

1. The Carolingian Renaissance

The origins of scholastic thought are linked to the attempt of culturization which, begun by Charlemagne, lasts till the 10th century. This task was possible thanks to England which had remained untouched by the invasion of the Gothic peoples. England had received the Catholic Faith before the disappearance of the Roman Empire in the West and the consequent cultural

upset, and of course the Holy See played a very important role in the evangelization and culturization of England. The classical Latin culture was flourishing there by the middle of the 7th century. We find in Canterbury the use of a plan of studies very similar to the Trivium and the Quadrivium proposed by Cassiodorus, but with the aim of understanding Holy Scripture better. Scarcely a hundred years later, the English undertake the task of evangelizing and culturizing the pagan people on the European continent. This was accompanied by the establishing of excellent libraries in Britain, around which important cultural centres of classical Latin culture grew. Among the important figures we find St. Bede the Venerable (673-735), who carried out a work of compiling knowledge, a work analogous to that of Cassiodorus (480-579) and St. Isidore of Seville (+636).

When Charlemagne conceived the plan of constructing an empire like that of the Romans, he considered as the first duty of his subjects their keeping themselves completely at the service of God in accordance with the Christian religion. He ordered in 789 that every diocese and monastery should open schools to teach not only reading and writing but also liberal arts, grammar, etc. Little by little these schools developed into the centres of intellectual life of the Middle Ages, till the birth of the universities in the 13th century, and from them comes the name of "scholastic philosophy" which is the name usually given to the philosophical speculation of this epoch. Moreover, Charlemagne assembled in his court the best minds of that time from different countries. The outstanding master was Alcuin (730-804), an Englishman educated in York, who enjoyed great prestige. More important than his writings is his work of civilization. He wanted to establish in France a new, a better Athens. Fulfilling his ideas, he organized the palace school, introduced the study of the Trivium and the Quadrivium which was followed in York and sent monks to Britain to copy the books in the best libraries, with the aim of distributing them in France.

Alcuin's influence was extended to Germany through his disciple Rhabanus Maurus (784-850), bishop of Mainz, whose influence on German culture earned him the title "praeceptor Germaniae." Under these two great men the cultural and literary restoration of Europe began. However, concern for philosophy is absent during this period of reconstruction. Only at the end of the 8th and in the 9th century do topics such as the substance of the soul, proof of God's existence, etc., appear again. For this reason, we easily see that the works of the ancients are accepted without criticism, like those of PsD.

2. John Scotus Eriugena and his Version of the Philosophy of the Fathers

John Scotus Eriugena (or Erigena) was born in Ireland in 810, and died probably about 877 in Paris. In 845 he was named head of the palace school. His figure dominates that whole epoch for he was a thinker with a well-defined philosophical doctrine. His mentality made him arrive - without theological caution - at the last logical consequences of his reasonings, some of which were condemned by the Church in 855 and 859. With John S.E a new Neo-Platonic current erupts with force from which the West will not be free till the metaphysical decadence of the 14th century. The genesis of his thought must be sought in the long work of translation of the "Corpus Areopagiticum" in which he wanted to offer the emperor Charles the Bald a more intelligible version of that work than Alcuin's translation. His main work is "De divisione naturae" which is full of very precise formulations in which he tries to transmit the philosophy of the Eastern Fathers, but he doesn't succeed in assimilating it adequately.

a) Reason and Faith

This is one of the main topics of the history of philosophy. In the case of John S.E. it becomes necessary to establish his concepts about faith and reason in order to grasp the meaning of his philosophy. He says that once God has been revealed, human reason finds itself illumined by faith. In this state, true wisdom consists in accepting the truth just as God has handed it down. On the other hand, human nature has an innate desire to know the truth. Therefore God wants faith to arouse in us a two-fold task, that of living it in our works and that of exploring it rationally in the contemplative life. What is first is faith. In it truth is given to us with absolute certainty and, following St. Augustine and PsD, he will sum up his thought with a phrase taken from the Bible: nisi credideritis, non intelligetis" (Unless you believe, you will not understand) (Ps.7, 9b).

Faith is a starting point, not a point of arrival, both for a holy life as well as for rational intelligence and for a knowledge which completes the faith. In order to achieve its aim, faith needs philosophical speculation which prolongs the effort of faith to reach its object. Though they are two distinct ways of knowing, they have the same content and in a certain sense are mixed together. In fact, one of the sources of Revelation is Scripture, but it is the task of reason, illumined by faith, to investigate the spiritual sense hidden in the words of Scripture, for an exclusively literal interpretation will lead to grave errors. The work of John S.E. is a philosophical exegesis of the Scriptures, in the style of Origen whose works he studied.

John S.E. lacks clarity and has too much enthusiasm. He affirms the primacy of faith and upholds the indisputable role of reason, but he is neither fideist nor rationalist. One must observe that he does not distinguish, within the revealed truths, between those which are and those which are not within the reach of reason. Thus he seems to rationalize dogma, and his philosophy is blurred within his theological and exegetical work.

b) Division of Nature

After pointing out that faith is the condition for rational knowledge, he indicates the method - Platonic in origin - for understanding what is believed: the dialectic (meaning something completely different from what Hegel, etc. mean by this term), in which one can distinguish two moments; namely, division, which begins with the unity of the supreme genera and comes down to the individuals, and analysis, which goes the opposite way. In reality it is a single movement of going and coming. These two operations are not arbitrary inventions of man, nor rules based on our way of knowing, but they make up the very law of beings, since what descends from the genera are the individuals themselves and not our reasonings. In other words, it is a law which is derived from reality and is in reality. The universe comprises all reality and at the same time makes up the concept of most universal content and thus receives the name "nature".

This notion, quite distinct from our notion of nature, includes all that is and all non-being. For John S.E. "being" and "non-being" are relative notions. Thus, "non-being" must not be understood as "nothing" but as anything which escapes the method of knowledge which dialectic teaches, such as privation, evil, the ineffable, the potential, the negative, etc. Limiting himself to the sphere of "nature" which includes being, he establishes the following division:

a) nature which creates and is not created (God the Creator);

b) nature which is created and creates (Ideas);

c) nature which is created and does not create (angels, man and other participated beings);

d) nature which does not create and is not created (God as End).

As can be observed, we have here really two distinctions, God and Ideas, and God and creatures, though the first distinction must later be clarified. Now "nature" is not a genus to which these four divisions belong, nor a whole divided into parts. His notion moves in the sphere of the Neo-Platonic concept of creation, which, like that of PsD, is equivalent to a real explanation of the production of the multiple starting with the One, which is difficult to reduce to the distinction between cause and effect.

c) Natural Theology

The nature which creates and is not created is God. From Him everything begins and to Him everything returns. God transcends all of our concepts, He is ineffable. Therefore, in order to arrive at Him, one must follow the method of PsD: affirmation, negation and supereminence. The last word always corresponds to negative theology, for to affirm, as example, that God is "hyper-essential" or "hyper-being" means that God is essence or being and at the same time that He is neither of the two, but rather a greater reality which is not specified. Hence, the way of supereminence expresses what God is not, though in an affirmative way.

d) The Ideas

The nature which is created and creates are the Ideas. John S.E. understands the Ideas as models of the creatures and their creative cause. But they in their turn are created by God the Father in the Word (the principal Idea) and thus they are co-eternal with the Word in time, but not in being, for they receive their existence from the Father. On the other hand, since they subsist eternally, they cannot introduce multiplicity into the Word for then they would go against the divine simplicity. Thus they are only distinguished in their effects (the creatures). The first consequence of this concept is that the Ideas are identical with the Word, which is absurd since they are models of the creatures, and hence they are creatures and finite, which impedes the identification.

Those who follow this doctrine stumble on this. This ambiguity is due to the concept of creation, which is conceived as a revelation of God - following PsD - and not as a production or causing of being out of nothing. To identify creation with revelation is to stress more the order of knowledge than the order of reality. The God of John S.E. would be like a Principle which, knowing that It is incomprehensible even for Itself, would unfold at one go Its power to reveal Itself, in which case the Ideas are the first "self-creation" of God. Since God is infinite and beyond being, to know Himself He must begin to be, and He can achieve this only by converting Himself into something else. Being is the first of His participations, but Being is not God. Thus, the divine nature is created and is known in the Ideas though they are finite.

It was said above that the two moments of the dialectic are complementary, and here we have an application of this. The Ideas can only appear by division of the first principle - it is God who gives them existence - and thus they are not God. In spite of this, the Ideas as expressions of God, are God Himself. In these conditions one understands that John S.E. can easily be accused

of pantheism. Here, he introduces the topic of illumination. All the creatures are lights in which the divine light shines.

e) Man and the World

The nature which is created and does not create is grouped into three blocks, angels, men and material things. In the thought of man, the corporeal universe subsists, as the inferior in the superior. Here John S.E. explains how the material world could have been created by God in man. He beings by defining matter as a union of accidents unintelligible in itself, though the accidents separately are understood. He concludes that matter is composed of intelligibles. God created the material universe in the Idea of man which subsists eternally in God. When man sinned, he dragged the world down, but man and the world must return to God. Since man can't do that now, it must be done by divine love. This return is done in stages and is the effect of nature and of grace at the same time. Evil will disappear, matter will be re-absorbed in the human body, this in the soul, the soul in the Idea and the Idea in God. This doctrine goes against several articles of faith, above all with regard to the disappearance of matter.

3. The Struggle Between Dialectics and Anti-Dialectics in the 12th Century

During the 11th century, the cultural panorama in the West was broadened, though the only profound thinker was St. Anselm. The Trivium was divulged more, while the Quadrivium maintained a timid life. The laity began to take interest in these studies. Some clerics took such an interest in dialectics and rhetoric that they relegated theology to second place and tried to subject dogma and Revelation to the rules of logic, thus making the instrument the centre of rational work and forgetting that all logic needs a metaphysics to sustain it.

One typical example is that of Berengarius of Tours (+1088), who considered logic as the best method for discovering the truth. He didn't hesitate to subject faith to reason and to translate dogmas in terms of reason. Along this path he came to deny the Transubstantiation and the Real Presence of Christ in the Holy Eucharist. His major work is one of the most complete summaries of Eucharistic heresies. Prescinding from the fact that he retracted his error before dying, one understands that there would be a strong reaction against those who maintained a philosophical attitude, for the faith was at stake.

A relevant representative of the anti-dialectic movement was St. Peter Damian (1007-1072). He defended theology against the abuse of logic and philosophy. He said that the only important thing is to be saved. Philosophy is not necessary for salvation, but is, rather, an invention of the devil. For him, philosophy must be "ancilla theologiae"

4. St. Anselm of Canterbury (1033-1109)

After John S.E., he is the first great philosopher of the Middle Ages. The greatest and most original part of his literary production is the fruit of his years in the monastery in Bec. In philosophy his greatest works are "Monologium", on the existence and essence of God without the use of Scripture, "Proslogium", "De Veritate" and some replies to the monk Gaunilon. St. Anselm discovers St. Augustine and tries to follow his example. Once a question is brought up, one must finish it. His work presents many ideas which will be developed later. In this sense it can be affirmed that he prepares the way for the great syntheses of the 12th and 13th centuries.

a) Reason and Faith

St. Anselm maintains an equilibrium position between dialectics and anti-dialectics. He holds that man has two sources of knowledge, faith and reason, and that faith has absolute primacy. He refuses to subject Scripture to logic. Man must always begin with faith and with everything which is proposed by way of divine authority: dogma, Scripture and the testimony of the Fathers. On the other hand, he defends the role of reason for the understanding of the faith. If it is presumption to subject faith to reason, he says, it is negligence to disdain reason because one possesses faith. What is bad about wanting to understand what one believes? The Fathers did so, and especially St. Augustine. The truth, however, is too vast and profound for mortals to grasp it all at once. Finally, to understand the faith to is come close here below to the very vision of God.

Thus, St. Anselm stresses that he does not want to understand in order to believe, but rather to believe in order to understand. But he lets himself be led by optimism about the interpretative role of reason by not setting a limit to this "understanding of faith." According to him, one can always come to understand what one believes, or at least, to understand the very necessity of believing it. St. Anselm thinks that through pure dialectic, one can come, not to understand the divine mysteries, but to prove by "necessary reasons" that reason, well conducted, must necessarily affirm them. He tries this with the dogmas of the Trinity and the Incarnation and St. Thomas will show later that this is impossible.

b) Natural Theology or Theodicy

What is most important in St. Anselm are the demonstrations of the existence of God. In the "Monologium" he has three of them, which complement one another. His reasoning is A POSTERIORI. He states in the first proof that we verify by the senses and grasp by reason that there are many different goods. Since they all have causes, we must see whether there is one cause or several causes of these goods. It is evident that where a more or a less of perfection appears, this is due to the fact that all participate in the one same principle. Therefore, all beings which have the aspect of good participate in the Good in Itself, which is God.

The proof of being follows that of good. The diversity of beings demands ascertaining their causes, which are evidently reduced to one single First Efficient Cause, because it is impossible that various causes exist which produce one another reciprocally.

The third proof is that of the degrees or the hierarchy of beings. There is a natural ordering, but this scale cannot be infinite. There can only exist one nature which is higher in perfection that all others, for if there were at the apex of this hierarchy of beings several equal ones, they would either have the essence in common, and hence would be one and the same being or they would have something else in common. Hence a being exists which is higher and more perfect than all the others.

In his "Proslogium" St. Anselm formulates his famous ontological argument, which is his desire to produce a rational proof for the existence of God. He states it in this way: One can say that, at least in one's mind, there exists such a being greater than which none can be conceived. If we are convinced of this, which is easy for everyone to understand, it means that that being is or has an existence in the mind. Since it is a question of the greatest being which can be thought, it must also exist in reality, for it is greater to exist in reality than only in thought. Therefore, that being undoubtedly exists, both in reality and in thought, and we call it God.

This argument has attracted many, for a philosopher can feel attracted by the notion of absolute being in his thought. For this reason the ontological argument has come up many times in history, though in distinct forms, in philosophers as unlike as St. Bonaventure, Descartes, Leibniz and Hegel. But not everything was clear in it. Very soon, the monk Gaunilon objected that one cannot argue from the existence of something in thought in order to affirm the existence of that thing in reality, that is, outside of thought.

St. Anselm acknowledged that one cannot and must not make this step or jump, but in the case of the greatest being which can be conceived, it is not only possible but necessary to make an exception. If one thinks about the greatest being and this does not exist in reality, it is always possible to conceive another greater being which does exist. The reply to Gaunilon leaves us back at the beginning, but it allows us to observe one of the presuppositions of the reasoning of St. Anselm which is none other than the notion of God that we have from faith. Who is this God in Whom we believe? The answer is obvious, the greatest Being Which can be thought. In order to affirm or deny His existence, one must begin with an idea about God, which, being the greatest and richest in content, cannot not exist.

In his turn, St. Thomas Aquinas also rejects the ontological argument, precisely because it does not begin with something existing in reality. Moreover, before bringing up the possibility of the existence of the absolute Being, it is necessary to define what one understands by greatest and most perfect Being. Well then, "a priori" it is impossible to know the nature of God, because of the weakness of the human intellect. Consequently, not everyone understands God as "that being, greater than which nothing can be conceived." In reality, the knowledge of God begins "a posteriori", that is, by the consideration of the effects (creatures) and along this way we arrive at a Being whose essence is His very Being.

Finally, St. Thomas affirms that it is not licit to go from the ideal or logical order to the real order. From the existence of something in thought, it does not follow that it exists in reality. St. Anselm has been able to formulate this proof because God is the one who cannot not exist. He is Being by excellence or ESSENCE, which means "full reality" and to say that ESSENCE does not exist means that the one whose nature it is to exist does not exist. Everything that is not God and yet exists is not "full reality" and has received being from it. Thus there are two modes of existing, that of God, in which essence and existence are identified, and that of the other beings, whose essence does not imply existence and in order to exist need to have God confer being to them. God has created the world out of nothing. To admit a pre-existing matter would be pantheism. Before creation, everything existed in God as an idea, but these ideas are not creative, as opposed to what John S.E. thought. After creation, God conserves the creatures.

c) Knowledge

In the face of anti-dogmatic nominalism, St. Anselm, imprecise in his explanation of knowledge, nevertheless upholds the reality of genera and species (the universals), though not as subsistent and as separate realities, otherwise theological orthodoxy would be endangered. If we don't grasp how several men joined in a species form one man, neither will we grasp that one God is in three persons. For St. Anselm, the ideas are beings, a metaphysical stance which reminds us of the "exaggerated realism" of Plato.

V. Philosophy in the 12th Century

The chief characteristic of the 12th century is the maturation of the whole cultural and philosophical patrimony received from Boëthius until St. Anselm, and constitutes the preparation of the new age of Western thought which the 13th century will constitute. We must highlight two lines:

a) The first line runs through St. Anselm and continues in the 12th century in Gilbert de la Porrée. It gives rise to a more abstract and technical Platonism, which will permit the assimilation of the Arabic philosophical doctrines. Since, in last instance, the framework of this speculative task is the Neo-Platonism of St. Augustine, this current is usually called "Augustinianism."

b) The second line involves the progress of dialectics or logic which will lead to the discussion of the problem of the universals and, with Abelard, to the necessity of entering into the metaphysical terrain for a correct solution. Along this line the logicians come into contact with the metaphysics of knowledge and the psychology of Aristotle. Thus, in the 12th century the conditions are set for a more intense absorption of both Neo-Platonism and of Aristotle.

1. The Controversy about the Universals

Along one path or another, the philosophers have always stumbled upon the problem of the universals. In the 12th century the approach has three modalities:

a) Those who follow Plato ask whether the ideas or the particular things are the true being.

b) According to Porphyry, are the genera and species (universals) real things or mental structures of our thought? Do they exist in the particular things or also separated in themselves?

c) And finally, as the question seems to have been put since Roscelin, are the genera and species (universals) only names or are they things? Those who give the first answer are called "nominalists" and those who give the second answer are called "realists."

a) Roscelin of Compiègne

Little is known about this man. His thought has come down to us through his adversaries, St. Anselm and Peter Abelard. According to them, for Roscelin, there is not colour, there are only coloured things; there is no wisdom, there are only wise men. In reality, we should give each thing a distinct name, but since the number of our words would be insufficient, we group several

individuals together under each name. The universals, then, only respond to two concrete realities, neither of which is genus or species or general idea:

a) to the physical reality of the word, taken as "flatus vocis" or emission of the voice;

b) to concrete individuals, which each word has the task of naming. It is right that he has been called the initiator of nominalism. At any rate, Roscelin would have to explain how these sounds, which make up a language, offer meaning to thought. One might have forgotten his doctrine but for its scandalous application to the Trinity.

b) Peter Abelard (1079-1142)

Peter Abelard is one of the most important personalities of the 12th century. He was a disciple of Roscelin and of William of Champeaux. His most important work is theological, but he was a philosopher also. He had a rare skill for his times, that of posing and solving philosophical problems without referring to theology. In the profession of faith that Abelard made at the end of his life, he said that dialectics were his ruin, since he was constantly using it in polemics which caused him to lose masters, friends and disciples. He also showed excessive confidence in the application of logic to dogma.

The one who first suffered his attacks was William of Champeaux, who at that time maintained that the universals were real, that is, things actually existing outside of the mind, and that the individuals to which the universal refers, are only distinguished from one another by accidents. Abelard objected that if the universal "animal" exists really and entirely in the species "horse" and in the species "man", then the animal nature is rational and irrational at the same time. The observation is correct. William changed his argument and said that the individuals of the same species have nothing in common, neither accidents nor essence, but rather an identity of "indifference" or absence of difference which is expressed by the universal. Abelard's reply was that "not to differ" is the same as "agree with", so that the same difficulties reappear. William of Champeaux then retired from teaching.

Abelard is both anti-realist as well as anti-nominalist, though his stance is influential in the nominalism of William of Ockham who later on absorbed or reduced metaphysics into logic. According to Abelard, universality is not of the things, but only of the words which have meaning (SERMO). If words were mere "flatus vocis" without meaning anything, it would be the same to say "man is stone" as to say "man is animal." But this second phrase is correct, thus the things have something which justifies the validity or invalidity of what we affirm about them. The foundation of the universal in the things is what is called "state" (STATUS) or the manner of being which is proper to the individuals.

Well then, the error of those who say the universals are real consists in confusing "man", which is nothing, with "to be a man = John." Likewise "horse" does not exist, but "to be a horse" is real. Definitively, Abelard observes that for a thing to be determinate, as the principle of non-contradiction demands, it must be determinate to individuation. Therefore all beings are completely distinct. Then what does the universal signify? The STATUS in which various individuals are found which are totally distinct. The solution of Abelard is clearly contradictory, for if the individuals are different, they cannot meet in any "state". Nevertheless, he will complete his theory with a psychological explanation which does not resolve the contradiction. Reason has the faculty of abstracting, that is of distinguishing what in reality is united, centring the attention on a single aspect. In this way, if we observe a group of things, we find that a

determinate aspect is found in several of them and from this collective we obtain a confused image which we designate with the word "universal" or SERMO.

Thus, if I say the word "tower", I have in my mind a weak, confused and very indeterminate image. On the other hand, if I say "the tower of Cluny", I represent a vivid and determinate image even in the details. The word "tower" is a universal and "the tower of Cluny" is real. Therefore, the word with meaning, or universal SERMO, is not a precise idea or concept. For this reason it can be said in general that man only has opinions, but man is capable of exact knowledge (science) of the concrete beings considered in an isolated manner. In summary, the universal or SERMO is only in the intellect, though it signifies in a confused way a plurality of real things. Only God distinguishes perfectly and clearly each one of the existent beings, in a unique and simple act of knowing, or, if one prefers, in a single Idea.

This solution that Abelard gives to the problem of the universals is basically purely logical, because he doesn't face up to what it is in the things which is the foundation of the universal predication. For St. Thomas, the universal expresses the participation which an individual has in a determinate nature. The nature "man" is not realized totally in the individual, (if it were, there would only be one man), but is participated by it, by the fact that its substantial form, the root of the perfection of the nature, is received in matter. In the mind, the NATURA HOMINIS acquires some special properties, since due to abstraction, it is separated from the individuating conditions.

Abelard is also important for his contribution to the scholastic method, especially accepted by St. Thomas. He describes it in his "Sic et non", in which he proposes technical rigour in treatises, and incites to investigation, bringing together around one and the same subject apparently contradictory testimonies of the Fathers, in order to look for their concordance.

2. Neo-Platonism in the School of Chartres: Gilbert de la Porrée

The school of Chartres is the most flourishing intellectual centre of the 12th century. Founded by St. Fulbert (960-1028), it acquires its maximum prestige with Bernard of Chartres (+1124) who establishes its definitive orientation. A certain Platonism dominates in this school, coming from very diverse sources, which include commentaries by Calcidius of some dialogues of Plato, some doctrines of St. Augustine, Boëthius, PsD and John S.E. Taken as a whole, three important positions are affirmed:

a) the creation of matter;

b) the identity of the Ideas and the divine Intellect;

c) that things are composed of idea (form) and matter.

The masters of Chartres are considered as "grammarians" in the ancient sense of the word, that is, educators who through classical literature form the style, the taste and above all the culture of the students. Nevertheless, in this century the "grammarian" undergoes the invasion of logic and consequently changes orientation. He no longer fosters humanistic culture, but gives rise to speculative grammar. Gilbert de la Porrée (1076-1154) is the greatest representative of the School of Chartres, and will be its chancellor from 1121 to 1140. He died as bishop of Poitiers, the city where he was born. His most characteristic points are described in the following sections.

a) The Forms

Gilbert's "De Sex Principiis" was studied widely until the 15th century. It is a metaphysical interpretation of the logic contained in Aristotle"s "Categories." Here he begins to deal with the principal problem which he posited, viz., the intrinsic formal cause of natural or composite beings. In accordance with the Platonic tradition of the reality of the universals or ideas (the Latins translated the latter as "form"), he divides the 10 categories into 2 groups:

i) the "inherent" forms, or substance, quantity, quality and relation;

ii) the "accessory" forms, or place, time, posture, "habitus", action and passion (the "sex principia" or six principles).

By "inherent" forms he understands the forms or principles which are the substance itself or inhere in it as such, which is so with the quantity or quality which are proper to the substance. Nothing hinders the substance from being caught up in a set of relations, but Gilbert doesn't explain their nature, thus giving rise to the controversy as to whether the relation is a real being or a being of reason, a topic of undoubted interest for the understanding of the dogma of the Holy Trinity. The "accessory" forms are only determinations or adjacent properties to the substance, which they affect more or less proximately.

b) Substance and Subsistence

In his commentary on Boëthius' "De Trinitate", Gilbert distinguishes between substance and subsistence. The first is an actually existing individual, a substance because it supports (substat) a certain number of accidents. As substance it is cause and principle of the accidents participating in its being. Subsistence is defined as the property of that which doesn't need accidents in order to be what it is. This condition is fulfilled on the one hand by the substance - every substance is subsistent - and on the other hand by those realities which are the genera and species, that is, the universals. The universals and species are not substances, but they are subsistences which for Gilbert have been created by God to the image of the divine Ideas (pure substances which subsist without ever mixing with matter). These genera and species taken in themselves are "subsistent forms". If they are considered with respect to bodies, they are the "substantial forms" which, united to the corresponding prime matter, give rise to the corporeal substance. That is, they are the substantial forms of the substance.

Consequently, each individual is informed by a generic subsistence, a specific subsistence and the substantial properties already mentioned above. In order to grasp the universals one must begin from these "substantial forms" in virtue of which the substances exist. Human reason can abstract in a body one of the "forms" and compare it with other analogous forms found in other bodies, so that it can come to construct a specific form. If it continues this work on a group of

similar species, it obtains a generic form, another universal. If the intellect succeeds in transcending this universal it reaches the eternally subsisting Ideas. It's good to recall that prime matter is not intelligible. Thus, Gilbert inherits from Boëthius the tendency to fix his attention on the form of the beings, which is intelligible, and he reduces the real beings to their intelligible elements. Thus he thinks about them abstractly, converting them into entitative constituents of the real being. We shall find this procedure later in Avicenna; Duns Scotus will develop it fully.

c) Degrees of Being

God, essential reality by excellence, is found at the apex of being. Everything which exists receives from Him its own essence. Taking Boëthius' distinction between "quo est" (form or "esse") and "id quod est" (the whole), he says that divinity is communicated to creatures by conferring "esse" on them. Creation consists precisely in producing a form to the image of the divine Ideas. This generic form determines the union of matter and the particular forms. Led by the absolute primacy of the "quo est" over the "id quod est", it seems that he maintains, along with the absolute divine simplicity, that the "id quod est Deus" is due to His "esse" or "essentia." Thus he was accused of distinguishing between God and Divinity.

Prescinding from the theological aspect, this distinction manifests the ultimate conception of Gilbert. For him, the things are composed of a subject and a set of determinations which make them to be what they are. Along this way, the topic of the formal constituent of the corporeal beings has been resolved, in a clearly Platonic line, but with metaphysical depth, which will render difficult and even slow down the understanding of Aristotle's hylomorphic theory. Gilbert is without doubt the most rigorous speculative spirit of the 12th century. If Abelard stands out by far in logic, Gilbert surpasses him as a metaphysician.

3. Speculative Mysticism

St. Bernard of Clairvaux (1090-1153) is the outstanding mystic of the 12th century, and the Augustinian monastery of St. Victor in Paris represents a corrective reaction in the face of the free application of dialectics in the field of faith. The personality of St. Bernard dominates his whole age and he is considered the "guide of the West", both in politics and in religion. He argues against Abelard, saying: "To want to know only to know, is shameful curiosity. To want to know in order to be known, is vanity. To want to know in order to sell knowledge, is a despicable business. To want to know in order to edify, is charity."

He elaborates in depth his doctrine of mystical love: True wisdom starts by meditation, by which the intellect places itself at God's service. One continues by contemplation or rest of the spirit in the certainty of eternal truths and finally with ecstasy the soul detaches itself from the activity of the senses and is divinized. Those who follow St. Bernard will incline more and more toward a religious moralism with Platonic elements. But those of St. Victor will show much more openness to profane knowledge. They teach that knowledge is always useful for union with God. Their considerations will have dialectic speculation with Platonic elements. This mysticism offers the first studies of psychology: the soul, the relation of the soul and the body, and of intellect and will, which will be systematized later on.

SUMMARY OF HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

VI. Jewish and Arabian Philosophy

1. Introduction

One of the elements that most contributed to the development of Western philosophy at the end of the 12th century and above all in the 13th century was the contributions of the Arab and Jewish philosophers. It is thus of interest to study their historical genesis and their principal representatives. Before Justinian finally closed the Athenian philosophical schools, the cultural patrimony of the Greeks had come to Syria and Mesopotamia in the hands of the Christians, for they needed it in order to read the Old Testament. When, two centuries later, Islam conquered that zone, it was usual that, along with theology in the schools, philosophy, mathematics, medicine, etc. were taught. The works of classical authors such as Euclid, Archimedes, Aristotle, etc. were translated into Arabic, either from Syriac or from Greek directly, thanks to the Abbasid dynasty, as well as works of more recent authors like Alexander of Aphrodisias and John Damascene.

In this way they received an Aristotle full of Neo-Platonic influences, so that other false works could be attributed to him. All of this will give rise to a Platonic-Aristotelian synthesis which will be held to be the doctrine of Aristotle in the 13th century. On the other hand, something occurs to Arab philosophical speculation similar to what occurs to that carried out by Christian authors. They also bring up the relations between philosophy and theology, reason and faith, that is, between a world which calls for an explanation and a unique God Creator Who is also known by revelation.

A positive attitude towards philosophy is found in Al Kindi who taught in Basra and Baghdad. He was an encyclopedist who died in 873. In his "De intellectu" he wants to explain the Aristotelian distinction between agent and possible intellect. He conceives the intellect which is always in act as a supreme Intelligence, a spiritual substance higher than the individual soul, which permits with its action in the soul the intellect of man to pass from potency to act. Thus is stated for the first time in Arab philosophy the thesis that there exists a separate Agent Intellect common to all men.

The work of Alfarabi (+950) who lived and taught in Baghdad is more fruitful. He opens the way for a metaphysical distinction between God and the world based on distinguishing between essence and existence in the creature. He indicates that natural beings are contingent, which is manifested by our notion of them. In fact, the idea of what a thing is does not include the fact of its existence. Thus if we pass from the logical to the metaphysical order, this means that existence isn't included in the essence of things, so for him existence is an accident which comes from the necessary Being. In another work he speaks of the separate Agent Intellect as a spiritual being which transcends the world and is the Giver of Forms.

In a diametrically opposed direction we find Algazel (1058-1111) who proposes combating the philosophers with intransigent fideism. He proclaims God's absolute omnipotence, denying causality in creatures.

2. Avicenna (980-1037)

Avicenna (Ibn Sina) is the summit of Arab metaphysics and one of the great philosophers of medieval history. Excellent in memory and intelligence he precociously assimilated all the knowledge of his time, especially medicine and philosophy. He led an intense political and intellectual life. Particularly important are his writings on logic, philosophy of nature, psychology and metaphysics. His philosophy can be characterized as a synthesis of Aristotelianism and Neo-Platonism which, as opposed to PsD and "Liber de Causis", grants no importance to the doctrine of participation. On the other hand, his philosophy is in full concordance with Islam. Thus the first point to deal with is the distinction between God and creatures.

a) Proof of the Existence of God and Creation

When several creatures are considered in thought, says Avicenna, one notices immediately that each of them is "something that is", but this notion is not simple, since it implies that in the being there is distinction between essence and existence, as Alfarabi had correctly said. The beings which have no real existence or which have only accidental existence are POSSIBLE BEINGS and that is what all creatures are. In other words, the possible being is either that which has no obstacles to exist on the part of the essence and it lacks only the accident of actual existence, or that being in whose definition of the essence existence is not included, as for example, any material being. Since possible beings exist, their cause, or necessary Being, must exist. The necessary Being is that which it would be contradictory to conceive or think as not existing, since its ESSENCE cannot be anything else than its ESSE, that is, the ESSENCE and the ESSE are the same thing.

For Avicenna the distinction between God and creatures is the same as between necessary Being and possible being. Now it happens that in the one, simple, unique, necessary Being, the action of creating is not voluntary and free, but is concomitant with its own nature, and in order to explain this, Avicenna finds support in the emanationist doctrine of Plotinus, binding it, like all the Arabs, to the astronomical knowledge of his time. From the emanationist principle that the One can only give rise to one, Avicenna deduces that since God is the intelligent Being par excellence, He knows Himself eternally and thus causes the First Intelligence. The tenth emanation gives rise to the separate Agent Intellect. The fundamental conclusion is that creation is necessary on the part of God and hence is eternal.

Moreover, Avicenna carries to the maximum the contingent character of the creatures. In fact, on one hand he affirms the distinction between necessary and possible being and on the other hand he maintains the absolute necessity of creation (necessitarianism). When he later on withdraws this doctrine in order to separate God from creatures duly, he necessarily will have to resort to the absolute affirmation of the divine freedom to create as we shall occurs also with Duns Scotus.

b) Philosophy of Nature

Avicenna conceives heaven as a series of 10 compact, concentric spheres, each with its own soul and body. The last, sublunar sphere is that of the separate Agent Intellect from which emanate the substantial forms of bodies and also the intelligible species or the knowledge of

those forms by human intellects. The substantial forms must be received by prime matter, but this does not occur in just any way, for prime matter in reality is matter deprived of form, that is, a kind of common nature which must be prepared to receive a form. What is needed is the action of external or second causes which take matter out of its indetermination and dispose it to receive some form. Also a principle of individuation is needed so that the prime matter is conditioned to receive a concrete form.

Avicenna was the first to teach that the principle of individuation is "materia signata quantitate" (matter designated by quantity). The "forma corporeitatis" and the second causes dispose matter to receive the specific form. The "forma corporeitatis" gives matter dimensions, and so the quantified matter is capable of individuating the specific form which it later receives, and the matter-form composite is the concrete being. One error of this explanation is that it admits the plurality of substantial forms in the being.

Avicenna established the distinction between the causes of being (ESSE) and of becoming (FIERI). God is the agent cause of being because He permanently produces actual being. The creatures, on the other hand, are causes of becoming or of movement. Moreover, the second causes (creatures, among which is the First Intelligence) are only able to dispose their effects. Together with this, he maintains a determinism in the physical order: in the same way that God cannot not create, once there is a cause an effect is necessarily produced. Along this way he will come to deny human freedom.

c) The Soul

Man is one of the beings of this world which, besides having a body, also has a soul, produced by the last heavenly sphere which in its turn is produced by the separate Agent Intellect (Dator formarum, or giver of forms). Thus it is an intelligible substance which can think and knows that it thinks, independently of the body which it animates. There is no substantial union between body and soul. In spite of assigning this origin to the soul, Avicenna maintains its immortality. Because of the soul, man has intelligence. How does he know? The intellect is a passive faculty in which the separate Agent Intellect impresses the intelligibles, that is, the form of the sensible beings.

Nevertheless, in order that the human intellect may be actuated in the indicated way, it must be disposed or prepared, by considering the images of the bodies perceived by the senses, by comparing them, classifying them, etc. Thus, the primary object of the intellect are the concrete individuals, and the secondary object is the knowledge of the essences. It is precisely at this last point that Avicenna begins his metaphysics.

d) Influence on St. Thomas Aquinas

St. Thomas knew very well the doctrine of Avicenna and he took many elements from it, though often he correctly them substantially. Here are some of the most important elements.

St. Thomas accepted the terminology "essence" and "esse", but he declares that "esse" is no accident, but the fundamental act of the being. For his third way of demonstrating the existence of God he makes use of the "necesse esse" and "possibile esse", but he restricts the range of contingent or possible being to the strictly corruptible, to corporeal beings.

St. Thomas does not accept the Avicennian necessitarianism or causal emanationism, because it opposes the Christian doctrine of immediate creation. Nor does he accept the principle of Plotinus that the One causes only the one, for the same reason and also because from that it follows that God has only indirect knowledge of creatures. For St. Thomas "esse" is a universal effect which is caused directly by a universal cause, God. St. Thomas makes use of the distinction between the causes of "esse" and the causes of "fieri", and also of some of the doctrine of abstraction, but he rejects the existence of a separate Agent Intellect, inadmissible for a Christian, and the Neo-Platonic error which reduces the role of the senses in knowledge. Thus, while St. Thomas moves on the plane of "esse", Avicenna moves on the plane of essence. In this sense he has much influence on the late Scholastics and through them on the modern epoch when the notion of being as act is lost.

3. Averroes (1126-1198)

Averroes (Ibn Rushd) must be placed in the same category with Avicenna as a philosopher. His most important works are the very literal "Commentaries" on works of Aristotle in which he wants to expound the genuine doctrine of the latter, purifying it of the Neo-Platonic and theological elements, so that the teaching of reason alone remains patent. If Avicenna represents a Neo-Platonic Aristotelianism accommodated to Arab theology, Averroes is much rather the figure of rigid Aristotelianism closed to theology with rationalist tendency. Hence the bad name which the first medieval Aristotelians had and the effort of St. Thomas to restore the true Aristotle. In fact, the main difficulties of the faith in the 13th and 14th centuries come from Averroism.

a) Reason and Faith

Averroes finds the cause of diversity in philosophical opinions in the constant interference of religious truths. Thus he tries to determine the relations between reason and revelation. For a Muslim divine revelation is contained in the Koran, the holy book which can and must be understood by all, each according to his own capacity. There are three levels of understanding of the Koran: the vulgar or literal, proper to simple people who like symbols and metaphors; the theological or dialectical, conforming to probable arguments; and finally the philosophical, demanding rigorous, conclusive demonstrations. Thus, it is the philosophers who discover the true sense of the Koran, the allegorical. Thus it is that every man must understand the only truth, the Koran, on his own level without trying to climb higher, without divulging what he knows to his inferiors for they wouldn't understand.

The conclusion for Averroes is simple: the philosopher has the last word, because he judges according to rigorous or necessary reasons, whereas the theologian remains in probabilities. This doctrine led to the theory of the double truth, which states that something can be true in philosophy and false in theology, and viceversa, though both can be simultaneously admitted. His ideas on the relation between reason and faith will be repeated in modern philosophy (Spinoza, Hegel).

b) Metaphysics

For Averroes metaphysics is the science of being as being and of its properties. "Being" must be understood as that which is here and now, whether substance or accident (which participates in the being of the substance). Hence it makes no sense to consider, as Avicenna did, being or "esse" as something apart and even less to affirm that it is an accident. Thus, Averroes identifies the actuality of being with the essence which makes it be what it is here and now, that is, he

remains on the Aristotelian plane of the substance in act. In agreement with Aristotle's physics, he comes to the demonstration of the existence of God as Pure Act by the way of movement and of finality. The world is necessary and eternal, for otherwise why would God create? The world was possible always, therefore it has been created by God from all eternity. Since God does not change and the world exists, he deduces that the world has been created necessarily. Averroes affirms the existence of beings necessary "ab alio" (the heavenly bodies). They are necessary because they are indestructible, not because they are necessary in themselves, but because of God, and they are subject to His domain.

St. Thomas will make use of this doctrine to combat Avicenna's contingentism, affirming that not all creatures are contingent, though created. Some substances - the spiritual creatures - are necessary "ab alio".

c) The Soul

All the obscurity of Aristotle's "De Anima" is equally obscure in Averroes' commentary, and he even adds new complications. The problem is basically this: in principle the soul should be a form
"educed" from the potentiality of matter by the creative action of God. But Averroes doesn't understand that this form can be a spiritual substance. He didn't doubt the spirituality of the soul or at least of a part of it, and consequently he affirms that it is not the form of the human body, that it constitutes a separate substance. Precisely because a determined body doesn't correspond to the soul, the soul is not multiplied nor individualized, and it is therefore universal. It is a Soul common to all men, like a collective "I". Whether one thinks that the intellect is what constitutes the soul or is simply a faculty of the soul, to affirm the existence of a universal Soul means recognizing the existence of a single Intellect for all men.

This is how the Averroists of the 13th century logically interpreted this doctrine. This common Intellect acts in man in a way similar to that of the separate Agent Intellect which Avicenna spoke about, but Avicenna admitted a personal intellect for every man. Regarding knowledge, the specific faculty in man is the cogitative, the highest sense faculty. Its function is to construct an image or phantasm with the impressions and sensations that the senses receive from the outside world. Thus, the unique intellect produces the intelligible knowledge in man, like the sun, by means of light, produces vision in the eyes.

St. Thomas, a commentator of the works of Aristotle who is just as literal as Averroes, though deeper, criticizes this by saying that man has the experience that he is the one who knows and who understands, and no one else. Hence, in each human subject there is a proper spiritual form or rational soul. Moreover, if only the cogitative were proper to each man, there would be no personal spirituality nor immortality, nor personal freedom and responsibility. Once this is said, St. Thomas accepts the doctrine of the cogitative (which Averroes formulated for the first time in history), giving it a central place in his metaphysics of knowledge, and showing the continuity between the personal intellect and the sensitivity (phantasm of the cogitative. With this he explains how man can grasp the material singular or the concrete thing.

4. Avicebron (1021-1058)

The Jews received the influence of the Arab philosophers. From this contact arose several Jewish thinkers in the 11th and 12th centuries. With Avicebron (Salomon Ibn Gabirol), Judeo-Spanish philosophy reaches a considerable height. Some of his 20 works are conserved. His main philosophical work is the dialogue "Fons vitae". Avicebron has passed into history as the defender in the West of the doctrine of universal hylomorphism and of the plurality of forms. This stance found notable echo in the Augustinian tradition, due to a common Neo-Platonism. The starting point of "Fons vitae" is the radical distinction between a personal God, simple and one, and creatures. To explain it, he affirms that all creatures, spiritual included, are composed of matter and form.

For Avicebron there is a universal essence or "prime matter", made up of a universal form and a universal matter, which is the only substrate or support for all the other forms. Thus, one being is distinct from another because of one or several complementary forms. There is a hierarchy of forms according to degrees of perfection so that the higher perfections include the lower, and according to the number of forms received, there is a mineral, a plant, an animal, etc. In its turn, there are two types of prime matter, simple matter and spiritual matter, which explains the difference between purely spiritual beings and material beings.

This doctrine arises from a confusion between logic and metaphysics. Avicebron identified the logical binomial "genus-difference" with the metaphysical binomial "matter-form". Hence the supreme genus is universal matter which in itself exists in potency, existing in act when it receives the successive forms. St. Thomas criticizes this doctrine for falsely affirming that potency cannot be found outside of matter. Every being is different from God because it receives "esse" as potency receives act.

5. Moses Maimonides (1153-1204)

Born in Cordoba and died in Cairo, with him Jewish philosophy reaches its apex. A very prolific writer, with his "Guide for the Perplexed" he exercised great influence in the West, especially on St. Albert and St. Thomas. This work, considered as the "Summa theologica" of Judaism, is based on a certain allegorical and rationalistic interpretation of Scripture and on philosophy (mainly Avicennian-Aristotelian, but without ignoring doctrines of Averroes). For Maimonides the Mosaic Law (Torah) and philosophy are knowledge of distinct kind, but absolutely incompatible. In reality, the proper object of philosophy is nothing other than rational confirmation of the Torah.

To show the existence of God he takes the arguments of Aristotle and Avicenna on motion, causality, and necessity and concludes that God is the Necessary Being, because He is Being. Moreover, God is absolutely simple, in Him essence and existence are the same, but creatures have being as an accidental addition. Though we know that God exists, it is impossible to know His essence. Any name given to Him expresses what He is not, even the positive names. On the other hand, he shows that Aristotle's arguments proving the world's eternity are not conclusive, not even those trying to establish creation in time. It seems more probable to him what is known by Revelation. The world has begun in time. Maimonides also points out that the proofs of God's existence don't depend on this point and thus keep all their value.

St. Thomas will accept this doctrine. Maimonides maintains, with Avicenna, that there is a separate and unique Agent Intellect which puts in act the passive intellect of each man. In this way Maimonides wants to stress the Old-Testament idea that God, thrice holy, is inaccessible. He says that man's end is to contemplate God, beginning with sense knowledge and

philosophical speculation aided by Revelation. To reach this end, he must be united to the separate Agent Intellect in its own realm, science. Since only the wise possess science, only they will achieve immortality.

6. The "Liber de Causis"

An anonymous Arab author of the 9th or 10th century wrote the "Liber de Causis" which passed as a work of Aristotle and influenced greatly Christian theologians. St. Thomas uncovered the falsity of this attribution and the Neo-Platonic basis of the work. He showed that its content is a summary of a work, Elementatio theologica of Proclus (410-485), a disciple of Plotinus. The author adds the correction that the first Principle, the One, is Creator and is God. The creation of the world is understood as a mediate action on the part of God since, according to this doctrine, what comes before everything else in the One or the first Principle, which in its turn is the Good in the Platonic sense. From the One everything else proceeds by steps. First of all is Being or Ens, the first hypostasis of the One, from which follow those of the first Intellect and the first Life. Beginning with these three realities or hypostases all things arise by participation from the three.

According to the work, "Esse" or "primum Ens" is a separate form created immediately by God. Then it gives being to things by way of creation, for it presupposes nothing, but the first Life and the first Intellect cause their effects in things by presupposing being, that is, by way of informing. Hence the creation of things is not caused directly by God. It must here be observed that this doctrine is the Platonic identification of the logical and the real orders. For the "Liber", the logical genera are subsistent realities and hence the maximum degrees of perfection. St. Thomas doesn't admit this concept, since "esse" is perfection itself, not a degree of perfection, but he does accept some few texts from this work, like "prima rerum creatarum est "esse" (the first of the created things is "esse").

For St. Thomas, this serves to indicate that the first act of creatures is their "esse". He also accepts the idea that the human soul is like the horizon of time and eternity, for it is the form of a body and at the same time a spiritual substance, and it is the lower limit of the purely spiritual creatures.

SUMMARY OF HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

VII. The Philosophy of the 13th Century

1. The Reception of Aristotle

About 1250, medieval philosophy reaches its greatest splendour. The most important cause is the arrival in the West of Arab and Jewish philosophy at an opportune moment, that is, when the state of thought was in condition to understand it and thus to assimilate it or reject it. In 1126 in Toledo the work of translating the works of the Arab philosophers began. With this impulse, the

Neo-Platonic current of Arab philosophy finds ample echo in the traditional central European Neo-Platonic line, fed by Boëthius, PsD, John S.E. and the school of Chartres.

What the Christian thinkers will reject are those things involved in the Neo-Platonic concepts of creation, understood as a necessary and eternal emanation from God, and the structure of the universe as well as the separate Agent Intellect. The Christians will correct Arab philosophy in these points, but not without work and vacillation.

For example, Amalric of Bène (+1206) seems to have been influenced by the pantheist interpretation of creation, which underlies the emanationist explanation, and affirmed that God was everything, as we see in the Church's condemnation in 1210. Also David of Dinant, influenced by a false interpretation of Aristotle, falls into heterodoxy. According to the condemnation of 1210, it seems that he maintained that God is prime matter, that God and the human intellect are one and the same thing, and hence all things are essentially the same, a pantheist affirmation.

Together with the "Metaphysics", the "Physics" of Aristotle arrived in Europe about the middle of the 12th century, contributing a set of useful principles and concepts to explain in a unitary and systematic way the corporeal beings. It had a great success and a rapid expansion in such a way that it was believed to be the only physics possible, while in fact this physics was impregnating the Arab treatises on astronomy, physics, medicine, etc.

The somewhat indiscriminate assimilation of this Aristotelianism and the change of mentality it implied provoked the preventive prohibition of the study of Aristotle's "Physics" in Paris in 1210. Later on Gregory IX, though he renews the prohibition in 1231, names a committee to expunge the errors of the Philosopher, a task which had already been initiated, more or less spontaneously, by the principal masters of the age.

By way of summary, the philosophical tendencies of the 13th century can be grouped together, according to the attitude and degree of assimilation of Aristotle, in the following way:

a) Franciscan Augustinianism which, for fear of pantheism, admitted some Aristotelian notions to distinguish God from things.

b) The Dominican current, which assimilated Aristotle better, so that it could disqualify Averroist naturalism which claimed to be the authentic Aristotelianism.

c) Latin Averroism, which accepted Averroes' Aristotle, not the historical Aristotle, doesn't reconcile religion and philosophy.

d) The development of the natural sciences, mainly in Oxford, under Aristotelian and Arab influence.

2. The Universities

The turn of the century brought with it an event of utmost importance for the cultural development of the 13th century: the foundation of the universities through the union in the same city of several schools. The first one was in Bologna, which was limited only to Law. The second and undoubtedly most important was that of Paris, where the masters and students of the cathedral schools came together to form a corporation recognized by Pope Innocent III as a university to which he granted statutes. From this moment, the Holy See will watch over the University of Paris, seeing that it could be teacher of truths or source of errors. In 1231 Pope Gregory IX recommended that the theologians should not boast about philosophers but should rather study human sciences only in so far as they can serve theology.

The University of Paris had four faculties: Church Law, Medicine, Liberal Arts, which will always tend to make itself the centre of purely scientific studies, taking no part in theology. Especially after the "arrival of Aristotle", its masters will not limit themselves only to dialectics, but will teach natural sciences. The fourth faculty is that of Theology, where Augustinianism predominates, with the instrumental aid of Aristotelian logic. After Paris in importance comes Oxford, which led a more autonomous life, since distance impeded the Popes from following its progress very closely. There the most traditional and Platonic Augustinianism predominated, and mathematics and positive sciences were cultivated.

In order to evaluate duly the philosophical and theological effort of this century, it must be noted that it is an eminently scholarly task, bound to the method of teaching. This consisted above all in the commentary of texts (LECTIO) of renowned authors like Aristotle or St. Augustine, and in the study of determined topics which, according to their importance, lasted 7 to 14 days (QUAESTIONES DISPUTATAE). At Easter or Christmas the monographic courses (QUAESTIONES QUODLIBETALES) were held, in which the great masters used to intervene. Finally there were three academic degrees: bachelor, license and Master (DOCTOR) and they were obtained in order to teach.

With regard to contents, the cathedral and monastery schools had revived, since Alcuin, the ancient patristic ideal of Christian "eloquence" as well as the study of classical Latin culture. Now the appearance of the universities coincides almost exactly with the "arrival of Aristotle" by many channels, so that little by little logic displaced the Latin culture of Cicero and St. Augustine and grammar was reduced to the indispensable, a school Latin to be able to read the Bible and the liturgical texts.

From the end of the 12th century, logic is converted into the new instrument of theology. On using the Aristotelian logic, the philosophy and metaphysics of Aristotle will be introduced. This is not something insignificant, for the vogue of logic transformed the ancient grammar, based on "authorities", into speculative grammar and thus into a study of the universal rules of language, rationally deduced.

3. The First Franciscan Masters in Paris

In the intellectual atmosphere just described, the "scholastic" philosophy is formed, which will remain united to theology for many centuries. If Plato and Platonism had been gradually "Christianized", now it's Aristotle's turn. If the first work had been slow, the Christian reinterpretation, distinct from mere exegesis, was comparatively quite rapid, presenting as a peculiarity the great diversity of points of view about the same topic. All of this is an unmistakable symptom of great activity and intellectual initiative on the part of the professors of

the universities and of the schools. In this context, it became difficult to fulfil exactly the indication of doing theology without any mixture of other sciences.

The first great figure of scholastic philosophy was Alexander of Hales (1170-1245) who settled down in Paris after finishing his studies in 1210. He became a Franciscan in 1231. Around that time the attitude of the Franciscans regarding studies began to change and the welcome accorded to Alexander in fact converted his chair into a centre of Franciscan studies. As professor, he shows confidence in Tradition, the Fathers and especially in St. Augustine. Also Boëthius, PsD, St. John Damascene and St. Anselm find a place in his "Summa Theologica." At the same time he opens the way for the assimilation of the new philosophy, though proposing numerous cautions, for he will always see Aristotle as a pagan and thus incapable of making authentic "philosophy" because he lacks the data of Christian Revelation.

John de la Rochelle (+1245), Alexander's successor in the chair of theology in Paris, is decidedly in favour of studies. He says it is diabolical to foster ignorance and those who attack philosophy must be considered as diabolical. The greater part of his writings is theological, though he wrote a work commonly accepted as a summary of Aristotle's philosophy of man, though he tries to harmonize it with the Augustinian viewpoint. In order to establish the distinction between God and creatures, Alexander of Hales had accepted the traditional formula of "quo est" and "quod est" and also Avicebron's doctrine of universal hylomorphic composition. But John de la Rochelle rejects this last doctrine, knowing that he is opposing his master, but he will not find Franciscan followers. On the contrary, his successors, Odo Reginaldus and St. Bonaventure return to Alexander's position.

John holds that accepting universal hylomorphism means assuming the existence of spiritual matter which he says is not possible. In fact, intellectual substances cannot have matter, for the intellect knows by means of intelligible forms which it receives in the condition of being completely immaterial. On the other hand, the intellect is fully immaterial, since it can receive any form, both of material and of immaterial beings. Moreover, when we abandon quantity, all determination of matter disappears, and so it makes no sense to speak of spiritual matter. Thus there is no room to speak about the composition of matter and form in spiritual substances, but only of the difference between "quod est" (concrete individual or subject) and "quo est" (form), a distinction which can also be applied to corporeal beings. This thesis will be defended by St. Thomas.

4. St. Bonaventure (1221-1274)

He studied in Paris under Alexander of Hales and taught until 1257, when he was named General of the Franciscan Order which he had joined around 1243. He was named Cardinal Bishop of Albano in May of 1273 and died a year later at the Second Council of Lyons. A man of intense and active life, he gave impulse and organization to the intellectual formation of the Franciscan Order. He wrote many works of philosophy, theology, ascetism and mysticism. His two greatest works "In IV Sententiarum" and "Itinerarium mentis in Deum" were written while he was Master in Paris.

a) The Spirit of St. Bonaventure's Philosophy

He was principally a soul of prayer, constantly seeking union with God. The knowledge that we have of God now is imperfect, but it is certain for it comes from faith, the starting point for the speculative force which the Christian needs if he wants to assimilate as much as possible the faith he possesses. In reality, life is a pilgrimage of man towards God, man raised to the

supernatural order then fallen into sin. Thus, the effort is rendered more difficult by ignorance and concupiscence. In order to overcome these difficulties, struggle and divine grace are needed. Grace is conceded through prayer and supernatural means. The spirit of prayer guarantees the rectitude of the will and is the foundation of the clarity of the intellect, the two conditions needed to be introduced into the life toward God. The pilgrim who follows this way finds God in every act of knowledge. Truth is hidden in the interior of things, for all of them are like a book which speaks about God and leads to Him. Thus, theology and philosophy are like two guides along this path which, though distinct in their methods, complement and continue one another.

For his work, St. Bonaventure leans on the theological and philosophical tradition of St. Augustine and St. Anselm, who have ploughed a broad furrow and like them he does not reject what can be useful in the "new" philosophy which invaded Paris. He in fact accepts the metaphysical doctrines of act and potency, form and matter, substance and accident, abstraction, agent and possible intellect, etc. But he will keep a serious distrust for Aristotle whom he considers a pagan philosopher and who is of no use to him for finding the One and Triune God whom he loves, nor for demonstrating the non-eternity of the world.

In summary, the line of force of St. Bonaventure's philosophical system is the itinerary which leads to God. For this he gathers the materials which are useful to him, whether theological or philosophical. Though he distinguishes perfectly between one and the other (reason and faith) he is more concerned in showing that the man who must travel along this path is wounded by sin, and that only by ascetical exercise and the grace of God will he reach his goal.

b) Natural Theology

St. Bonaventure makes his own the favourite proof of St. Augustine for the demonstration of God's existence, going so far as to make it implicitly the conducting line of his reasonings. It is the argument based on truth and the existence of eternal truths. He proposes it in this way: in every proposition something is affirmed as true, even when one says "there are no truths", for this denial is affirmed as true. To affirm a truth implies the existence of the basis and the cause of the truth. Since the truth or the light which the intellect possesses is limited, it necessarily demands the existence of the Immutable Truth or Infinite Light, which is God, cause of all truth. The human intellect is certain of a truth when it is guided by the light which brings forth the truth itself. Hence to deny the existence of God supposes denying the source of light and of truth, precisely in the name of what comes from that source, which is absurd.

With these pretexts, it seems clear that the truth in things is only a representation of the divine Truth. Thus the first step of the itinerary towards God is to find the traces of the Creator in the sensible world, something which seems easy. But St. Bonaventure does not present any way as an argument, but rather tends to sketch a multitude of ways, since he thinks that they are not necessary when one has arrived to God along any of them. The second step consists in discovering the image of God infused in the human soul. In the corporeal world we see only reflections and shadows of God in things, but on looking at the soul we contemplate an image of God since the condition of the soul is nothing else. This presence of God in the soul makes His knowledge immediate. If the presence of God in the soul is the basis of the immediate knowledge of God, evidently the idea that we have of Him necessarily implies His existence.

Therefore, illumined by this ever-present idea, it is impossible for the soul to think that God doesn't exist.

Here St. Anselm's ontological argument crops up, which St Bonaventure accepts and formulates: "if God is God, God is." In another direction, he will reach the consequence that the idea of God is implied in every intellectual operation, not only from the point of view of the truth, but also of the contents of thought: it is possible to know the particular as something imperfect by the presence in us of the idea of the Perfect. But through all this knowledge man will never arrive at the full comprehension of the Divine Essence. The third step of the itinerary is the mystical knowledge of the divine presence, which is the concern of theology.

c) Psychology

Attracted by the Augustinian concept of man, an attempt to synthesize Aristotle and Plato, St. Bonaventure holds the soul to be a complete, simple, immortal substance created by God, form or act of the human body and present in the whole body. The intellect is not in the same situation when looking at bodies as when looking at the world of the soul and of God. In the first case it is "tabula rasa" and to know bodies it needs abstraction, an operation common to the agent and the possible intellect, by which it retains data of the sense images. In the second case, it isn't possible to know God or oneself by abstraction. The soul always is present to itself and God even more so and there is no sense image of either. Nor is there intuitive knowledge of either. St. Bonaventure uses a Platonic solution, his illumination doctrine.

d) Theory of Illumination

God is immutable and infallible, but man is not. Nevertheless, man is capable of possessing certain and firm knowledge. The only way to explain this fact is that God illuminates the intellect by means of His ideas. The action of God's Ideas consists in arousing some necessary truths, in relation to which we know, and in giving certainty to the intellect. These Divine ideas are never the object of knowledge but rather in them and through them we know how the things must be. For this reason, on earth our knowledge is never perfect. Man has, then, his own natural light in order to know what is particular in the sense world, but in order to know what is universal he needs an additional light, by means of which he can relate the particular being with its eternal and necessary essence. The imperfect is known through the notion of the perfect which is in us (the necessary truths or principles of philosophy), through the light due to the divine Ideas.

But one must not understand the Ideas as beings distinct from God, for that would be heresy. The divine Ideas are God, at once transcendent and present in man and in things. St. Bonaventure does not explain the nature of this new or added light, if natural or supernatural, only that it comes from God. Here his disciples will stumble and will neutralize his theory of illumination.

e) Creation: Exemplarism, Principle of Individuation and Seminal Reasons

St. Bonaventure reacts strongly against the Arab philosophers' theory of necessary and eternal creation and comes face to face with its Aristotelian source. In many ways he argues that it is a contradiction to think of an eternal creation on the part of God, as it is impossible to go through an infinite series of beings. If the world had existed from all eternity, by now it would have reached an infinite duration, which is impossible, etc. St. Thomas will show that neither Aristotle's arguments nor those of St. Bonaventure are conclusive. Nothing can be proven metaphysically and only through faith can we know that the world has been created in time.

According to St. Bonaventure, to explain the fact of creation it is completely necessary to accept the doctrine of exemplarism as St. Augustine proposed it. God knows Himself perfectly and this act of knowledge is the image and expression of Himself, that is, the Word or Son, who shows all that the Father is and can do. Hence, the "Ideas" of all creatures, past, present and future, are contained in the Word, from genera and species (the universals) to singulars. This doesn't mean that in the Word there is an infinity of ideas, but only one, which is not distinguished from the Divine Essence. Nevertheless, reason can differentiate them, not really in God, but in the multiplicity of creatures by distinction of reason. God's creative efficacy causes the being of creatures in conformity with the Idea or exemplary ideas. There is a real distinction between God and creatures, in which it is necessary to distinguish the "quod est" and the "quo est", as Alexander of Hales teaches.

St. Bonaventure's explanations of this point don't let us decide whether he arrived at the distinction between "essentia" and "esse" or if he remained on the logical plane, like Boëthius. St. Bonaventure is enthusiastic about universal hylomorphism. Every creature is composed of matter and form. Matter is pure potency. The form determines whether a being is material or immaterial, and thus is established the existence of a corporeal or a spiritual matter. From this he deduces the immortality of the soul. Since the soul is a complete substance, it can subsist independently of the body. In fact the soul, though it has the aptitude and inclination to inform the body, has principally been created to possess God. Likewise, the angels are also composed of matter and form and hence can be individuals of the same species, like the souls. Since all creatures have the same metaphysical structure, the individuation of each one cannot come from matter or form, considered apart, but originates from the union of both.

On the other hand, the form is not unique in the Aristotelian sense, but each being has a plurality of forms in a perfect hierarchy, so that they constitute a unity. The form common to all beings is light, the first substantial form to which specific forms are added. Thus there is a scale of beings. Here we are fully in the Augustinian line and in that of Plato, who had compared the Good with the sun which spreads its rays of light and illuminates the things. God does not limit Himself to creating and conserving things, but He penetrates them interiorly in all their actions. The world and the corporeal beings are not outside of the divine terrain, and St. Bonaventure accepts the theory of the "seminal reasons" of St. Augustine, since it permits him to accentuate the work of the Creator and lessens the independence of natural beings. The matter of the universe contains the seminal reasons, virtual forms in latent state of everything which comes afterwards. Just as the seed can't modify its fruit, the efficacy of the second cause ends precisely in the effect foreseen by the Creator.

f) Balance of the Philosophy of St. Bonaventure

St. Bonaventure didn't fix any philosophical principles in order to elaborate a metaphysical system afterwards. He is oriented in another direction, with a peculiar spirit. First of all, he wants to gather the philosophical elements which are offered to him from different sources, especially from St. Augustine, either directly or under the interpretation of other authors, as for example the universal hylomorphism of Avicebron, or the plurality of forms of Avicenna, etc., a fact which St. Thomas will criticize.

Secondly, the plurality of sources must not disorient since the materials are grouped around the three central points of St. Bonaventure's metaphysics: creation, exemplarism and illumination. Creation explains the world as the work of the Creator beginning from nothing and depending entirely on God, exemplarism reveals the intimate union between God and creatures, as the model and the copy. Illumination deals with the threefold path of the soul to God. St. Bonaventure is a mystic. His philosophy is that of a theologian, with theological method and aim. This implies at times a confusion of planes, since he doesn't distinguish well between the natural and the supernatural. His work leaves behind a collection of Augustinian ideas which will be diffused by the Franciscan schools for a long time.

5. The Franciscan School

Begun by Alexander of Hales and brought to its splendour by St. Bonaventure, it finds in Matthew of Aquasparta (1240-1302) a defender of such drive that he brings doctrinal positions to a limiting situation. His works are practically unpublished and thus aren't very well known. What we do have are some points of the doctrine of his master, St. Bonaventure. He rejects the real distinction between essence and esse, which seems to him a merely verbal distinction. In fact, the old Franciscan school thought always that existence adds nothing to essence, and that existence is nothing else but the essence placed in relation with its efficient cause, God. Hence Matthew of A. tenaciously holds the hylomorphic composition of the soul. He opposes the Thomist doctrine of causality with the Augustinian theory of seminal reasons.

His psychology is more radical. St. Bonaventure had admitted a natural knowledge, starting with experience and completed by abstraction, even though the intellect was assisted by an additional light. Nevertheless, for Matthew of A. all knowledge requires the light of the divine Ideas (immediate action of the Idea in the intellect), but this light is somehow superior to the simple natural influence of God. In these conditions, his version of the doctrine of illumination signifies that the formal cause of all human knowledge is a supernatural action or light which only theology can explain. Thus any frontier between natural and supernatural knowledge is erased. Therefore, Matthew of A. maintains that the object of intellectual knowledge is not the things just as they present themselves exteriorly, but rather the Ideas of the things in God.

Rather than making a contribution, Matthew of Aquasparta aggravated the situation. Therefore other Franciscans appear, like Peter Olivi (1248-1298), Peter of Traves, Richard of Middleton, who desire to be faithful to the traditional opinions of the Order and fall back to more moderate positions. Nevertheless, in some cases the revision will impose a renunciation of some point of Augustinian doctrine. The topic of seminal reasons will be modified as will the doctrine of illumination, with the aim of salvaging natural knowledge. Limiting themselves to this last point, some authors will expressly say that God is not the light of the intellect in all knowledge, but that the intellect has its own light in order to reach its object, and thus the way is open for other authors to make a psychological description of the process of knowledge.

There is also a broadening of intellectual perspective on the occasion of the controversies between Augustinians and Thomists, which in first instance can be codified in the condemnations of the Bishop of Paris, Stephen Tempier, in 1277. One of the reproved theses was directed against Greco-Arab necessitarianism and signified a revolution in the traditional cosmological conceptions. In fact, the condemnation was equivalent to acknowledging that the world in which we live isn't necessary nor is it the only one possible for God. In this line we find Richard of Middleton who dares give peculiar hypotheses about the world: that God can make the universe grow indefinitely, that a plurality of worlds is possible, that all the heavenly bodies can have a rectilinear motion, etc. The important thing here is that these ideas broke the unity of the Augustinian doctrines and the diversity increased in spite of the good intentions of their defenders.

Here we must also include two diverse figures such as Duns Scotus (1266-1308) whom we shall study more later on and Raymond Llull (1235-1315). This latter dedicated his life to the ransoming of Christian captives of the Arabs. His apostolic zeal led him to make many trips to North Africa to preach the faith. He posed the following problem: the Moslems deny Christian divine revelation and the Averroists reject it in the name of the supremacy of reason. In order to resolve this conflict between religion and philosophy it is necessary to start with concepts common to both Christians and Moslems and construct a system of possible combinations of these common concepts (Leibniz confessed that this was the first antecedent of one of his own philosophical ideas) and the relations of the doctrine of illumination. One of the conclusions is that if creatures are illuminations of God, the art of combining the perfections of creatures of all possible types will show us all possible combinations of divine perfections. Thus Llull repeats the idea that the one existing God has created or illuminated the one world which manifests him, a conclusion of his doctrine of illumination.

6. The Masters of Oxford

The University of Paris becomes more and more dominant in the cultural atmosphere in France in the 12th and 13th centuries, imposing on it a method of work. Since Abelard, logic constitutes the basis and the technique of any philosophical and theological activity. However, the Neo-Platonic spirit of the school of Chartres is reborn in Oxford, permitting the assimilation of Arab science, charged with Platonism in philosophy and with Aristotelian elements in the natural sciences.

The first representative of this tendency is Robert Grosseteste (1175-1253). He knew Greek very well and he translated and commented several works of PsD., as well as several works of Aristotle, though he constantly disagreed with the latter. Under the influence of the Arab treatises on optics, he wrote "De luce" in which he develops a theory of light, and with the help of geometry, he tries to explain the structure of the universe. The world is the result of a point of light created by God out of nothing, in which the luminous form and matter are evidently unextended.

Roger Bacon (1210-1292), a commentator on the books of physics and metaphysics of Aristotle, went to Oxford in 1247 where he was a disciple of Robert Grosseteste and became interested in experimental studies of nature. He became a Franciscan in 1257, but he was neither understood nor tolerated by his companions. His astrological theories were considered as being included in the condemnations of 1277 of the see of Canterbury and he was imprisoned until shortly before his death.

Like all the Scholastics of his time, Bacon was first of all a theologian. For him the only perfect wisdom is theology and in order to explain it one needs philosophy and canon law. Like St. Bonaventure, he reduces all arts to theology. In his "Opus maius" he explains that philosophy is the fruit of divine illumination in man. Everything began with the Revelation of God to our first parents, but soon sin obscured this wisdom and human history is nothing other than the rediscovery and relosing of this wisdom. Here Roger Bacon feels that he is a prophet in a century of barbarism, for he thinks he knows the method of reconstructing that science whose first principles were contained in the primitive Revelation.

The first condition for restoring philosophy is to free it from the superstition of authority, of which something is admitted as true only because it is maintained, for example, by Alexander of Hales or by Albert the Great (expressly citing representatives of the Franciscan and Dominican schools). The only masters whom he admires are those, like Grosseteste, who have shown the necessity of mathematics and of experience. Bacon's affection for mathematics was great, up to the point of considering it necessary for every science, even theology. In part six of his "Opus maius" he explains his position: "there are two ways of knowing, by demonstration and by experience. The demonstration concludes and obliges to admit the conclusion, but it doesn't give us certainty or take away all doubt, in such a way that the soul rests in the truth. For this, experience is needed." Thus experience is what is most necessary because it can even reinforce mathematical evidence.

There are two classes of experience: internal, which leads us to the heights of the interior life and mysticism; and external, acquired through the senses. This latter is the origin of all scientific knowledge and is thus the basis of the perfect science, which Roger Bacon calls, for the first time in history, experimental science. Experience calls forth a complete certainty and it

can also be continued at the point in which all the others come to a halt and allow us to discover the secrets of nature.

Robert Kilwardey, O.P. (+1279) is another student of Paris and professor of Oxford who became Archbishop of Canterbury in 1272. Concerned with the controversies about Aristotle he took advantage of the condemnations of Stephen Tempier - 7th March 1277 - to maintain the Augustinian positions. Thus on March 18th he published 16 propositions prohibited to be taught in the University. The doctrines prohibited imply the acceptance of seminal reasons in explaining the causality of creatures and also of the plurality of substantial forms.

His successor as Archbishop of Canterbury, John Peckham (+1292) renewed in 1284, though less zealously, the condemnations of 1277 and added a few more to them. Nevertheless, his concerns were of diverse nature. He was sorry to see that the opposition of doctrines led to opposition between Franciscans and Dominicans and he wanted to avoid that. He detected that the points of dispute were the doctrine of illumination, the seminal reasons and the unity of the potencies with the essence of the soul. In short, if one can prescind or not from God in order to know and to explain the things of nature. The attitude toward this problem defines the value which was granted to the doctrine of St. Augustine. It is not longer only a critico-philosophical problem, but rather it underlies a whole theological problem.

7. St. Albert the Great

A German by birth, he studied arts in Padua where he became a Dominican at the age of 17. He obtained the doctorate in Paris where he taught theology. Among his students was St. Thomas Aquinas. He fixed his residence in Cologne in 1248, where he died. He enjoyed great prestige in the whole Western cultural world. He was praised even by a man so hard to please as Roger Bacon. St. Albert was an avid thinker in science, one who was well versed in the various schools of philosophy and who thought about bringing together the doctrines of Plato and Aristotle. His ample work can be considered as encyclopaedic. He wrote treatises on theology, philosophy, natural sciences, physics, biology, etc. He is not a simple compiler. Though he undertook to transmit the logic, metaphysics, physics and ethics of Aristotle and make them intelligible to the Latins, he also purified them as much as he could from the Arab interpretations, pointed out the errors of Aristotle and often commented on them, giving his own personal interpretation. He didn't systematize his immense work, but it supplies precious material in philosophy and theology to St. Thomas Aquinas, who uses it for his profound doctrinal synthesis.

a) Reason and Faith

St. Albert starts from two things, the data of faith and those of experience. Thus his attitude towards the sources of knowledge is very determined. He recognizes in St. Augustine an indisputable authority as theologian, but not in other fields, in which he asks for explanations. The principle "credo ut intelligam", which without doubt affirms a truth, contains a habitual confusion in his followers between believing and knowing. Nevertheless, "to know" is distinct from "to believe". Thus St. Albert succeeds in distinguishing between philosophy and theology. The latter is concerned with data of faith, of the indemonstrable mysteries such as the Trinity, etc., that is, of all that is known exclusively through Revelation. Philosophy is guided by the

faculty granted to all men, which is reason. Under its light one can acquire truths from sense experience.

Thus the authority of a philosopher is based on the value of his demonstrations. Together with theology, in which the intellect is guided by Revelation, there is also a theological metaphysics which is concerned with God as First Being in the light of reason. It is not surprising then that St. Albert severely censured the detractors of the use of philosophy with expressions such as: "brute animals who blaspheme what they don't know." Let us observe that here we notice the spirit of Thomist philosophy, along with some fundamental theses: reason has its own sphere of operations; natural knowledge always begins with sense experience. It is St. Albert, and not Luther or Descartes who establishes the rights of reason back in the 13th century.

b) Psychology

In general, the doctrine of St. Albert is little studied, perhaps because its dispersion throughout his works makes it difficult to analyse its evolution. Nevertheless, his doctrine on the soul is an exception. In it we find an amalgam of Greek and Arab elements and an attempt to reconcile Plato and Aristotle. St. Albert thinks, like Aristotle, that the soul is form of the body, but this functional definition doesn't reflect its essence, so he prefers Avicenna's definition that the soul is an intellectual substance. As such, it knows universals, or ideas "post rem". The universals "ante rem" are the Ideas in the divine intellect or separate agent intellect, which is God. Divine illumination of creation radiates forms or ideas in matter which gives rise to the universals "in re", which are the causes of the being and the intelligibility of substances. Finally, when the soul frees the form from matter, it knows the universal "post rem", which evidently must coincide with the divine Ideas. Since the soul is a complete spiritual substance, it possesses in itself the principle of knowledge: the agent and the possible intellect.

In man, the light of his own agent intellect makes the forms of the sensible things intelligible. Thus, the process of knowledge can discover them. This process begins with the images coming from sense experience. The agent intellect illuminates them and abstracts the forms which the possible intellect will receive. This latter relates them with the first principles of natural reason in such a way that they give rise to, so to speak, a cultural patrimony which will allow one to judge other experiences and to formulate judgements. It becomes necessary to know and to study, for the soul, by means of knowledge, is more itself. In fact, through the agent intellect man is similar to God.

c) Disciples

The immense cultural contribution of St. Albert will be continued in two directions. On the one hand, by St. Thomas Aquinas, who will re-elaborate a good part of all this material, mainly his doctrine on knowledge. On the other hand, a set of disciples will perpetuate his doctrine without any special corrections, stressing perhaps the Neo-Platonic elements of Avicenna and Aristotelian concepts, used more as philosophical technique than as science. Through this set of disciples St. Albert becomes a link in the intellectual current which starts with PsD and comes to Meister Eckhart and Nicholas of Cusa.

8. Latin Averroism

Under Latin Averroism we designate the assimilation of the "new Aristotle" by the Faculty of Arts of the U. of Paris in the 13th century. We shall make more precise the meaning of "new". It

is not the use of logic introduced already by Abelard which we find throughout the 13th century, nor is it the better knowledge of Aristotle's doctrines and their assimilation, in different ways, in the theological syntheses of the great masters of the Faculty of Theology of Paris, like St. Thomas and St. Bonaventure. It is the "Averroism" which arises in the Faculty of Arts when some masters abandon the habitual commentaries of Aristotle's logic and begin studying the scientific works with a "new" spirit. They conceive philosophy as an end in itself, outside of the synthesis of theology and philosophy into which it must enter. They also understand the doctrine of Aristotle as that which Averroes attributes to him (the "new Aristotle") and that this doctrine is identified with the full philosophical truth. When such an attitude took shape, a rash of doctrines charged with pagan naturalism broke out in the University, which provoked numerous violent discussions up to the point that the Church authorities had to intervene.

In 1256 the Pope asked Albert the Great to refute the error of Averroes that there is only one agent intellect for all men. In 1270, Stephen Tempier, Bishop of Paris, condemned 15 theses, 13 of which were Averroist. Those condemned excused themselves on the basis of the theory of the double truth: as theologians they denied what they affirmed as philosophers. Consequently, early in 1277 Pope John XXII issued a very severe bull admonishing the masters of the Faculty of Arts of the U. of Paris. Stephen Tempier took advantage of this on 7th March of the same year to extend his condemnations of 1270 to 219 theses, including many of those previously condemned, but now going more to the root. Some of the theses condemned were later on accepted, after a further study had been made, such as St. Thomas' doctrine of the unicity of the substantial form. Since the discussions were becoming more and more bitter and professors were anathematizing one another, the Roman Curia ordered the suppression of the excommunications attached to Tempier's 1277 condemnations, for the only thing of interest was safeguarding the faith. A more precise study of the 219 theses and their exact meaning was undertaken.

One of the most characteristic exponents of Averroism was Siger of Brabant (1235?-1282), a restless and very talented cleric who headed the rebel movement against the Rector of the U. of Paris, Albaric of Rheims. Obliged to give up teaching in 1277, Siger died in Italy, leaving behind a trail of rationalist shading that remained in Italy until the 16th century. Siger wanted to base his teaching on Aristotle and thought during his lifetime that he was doing that. Nevertheless, rather than reproducing Aristotle’s doctrines, he was taking Averroes' version of the Philosopher’s teaching. To hear Aristotle, he said, is to hear the voice of science and of reason. Of course, there is another absolute and true science, which is Revelation and therefore, when there is a conflict between them, one must acknowledge the supremacy of faith, but maintaining the other doctrine on the philosophical plane (the theory of the double truth).

One example of this is Averroes' doctrine of the unicity of the intellect and of the soul, which one must accept while at the same time accepting theologically that each person has an individual soul. Siger had many other such teachings. His doctrine was strongly attacked by St. Thomas Aquinas, up to the point that it is one of the few occasions in which he manifests great vehemence in his refutal of error, as opposed to his habitual serenity. See, for example, his work "De unitate intellectus", chapter 5.

VIII. St. Thomas Aquinas (1225-1274)

1. Introduction

St. Thomas comes from a Lombard family which settled in the castle of Roccasecca, near Aquino in the province of Naples. He was educated in the monastery of Montecassino where the abbot was an uncle of his. When Frederick II expelled the monks in order to make a fortress of the monastery, St. Thomas continued his studies at the U. of Naples. There he met Peter of Ireland who introduced him to the philosophy of Aristotle. About 1244 he became a Dominican, against the wishes of his widowed mother and he was imprisoned at Roccasecca by his brothers. He made use of his imprisonment in order to reread the Holy Scriptures and to study the "Book of Sentences" of Peter Lombard and a work of Aristotle. At the end of 1245 he fled from his prison and after a brief stay in Naples, he went to Paris where he was taught by St. Albert the Great. Both of them were together for 4 years in Cologne, where St. Thomas studied the works of St. Albert as well as the "corpus dionysianum", the "corpus aristotelicum" and the Arab commentaries.

After being ordained a priest, he returned to Paris in 1252 as professor and wrote his commentary on the "Book of Sentences". At that time opposition arose against the Franciscans and the Dominicans being named as masters at the U. of Paris. The question was resolved by Pope Alexander IV granting them permission to do so. During this time in Paris, which lasted till 1259, St. Thomas wrote, among other works, "De ente et essentia", "De principiis naturae", "De veritate" and some Scripture commentaries.

He was called to Rome in 1259 to be Master of the pontifical Curia and he remained there till 1268. He taught in Rome, Viterbo and Orvieto and he organized the Studium Generale of the Dominicans in Santa Sabina in Rome. At the pontifical court he met William of Moerbeke who supplied him with first-hand translations of the works of Aristotle which he used for his commentaries. During this period he wrote "Summa contra Gentiles" and the first chapters of "Summa Theologiae" as well as a commentary on PsD's "De divinis nominibus" and some other works.

In 1269 he returned to Paris to defend the rights of the mendicant orders to teach at the University. He got involved in the defence of Christian doctrine against the Averroism which had engulfed the Faculty of Arts and wrote several works, among them "De unitate intellectus", for this purpose. His own doctrine on the unicity of the substantial form was condemned by the Bishop of Paris in 1270 and St. Albert spoke up to defend his disciple.

In 1272, St. Thomas was destined to Naples where he had the chair of theology. There he continued the "Summa Theologiae" and wrote several other works, such as "De substantiis separatis". He was invited by Pope Clement X to take part in the Second Council of Lyons, but he died on the journey to Lyons in Fossanova on 7th March, 1274. Pope John XXII canonized him in Avignon in 1323.

2. Principal Works of St. Thomas

The works of St. Thomas can be put into two groups: first, the works destined for teaching, bound to the method of university education of his time; second, those written for apostolic needs and assignments and for preaching. To the first group belong the commentaries on official text books. We refer to the Holy Scriptures (Job, Psalms, Jeremias, Isaias,

Lamentations, Gospels of St. Matthew and of St. John, Pauline Epistles); the "Book of Sentences" of Peter Lombard (which was used as a theology text till the 16th century); PsD's "De divinis nominibus"; "De Trinitate" and "De hebdomadibus" of Boethius; "Liber de causis"; etc. and the commentaries on 13 works of Aristotle.

With regard to these latter, an interesting novelty is observed. He keeps faithfully to the literal exposition of the text and points out errors committed by Averroes' commentaries. Once the Aristotelian doctrine is reached, St. Thomas strives to attribute to it the greatest possible degree of truth, but without doing violence to the text. On other occasions, St. Thomas finds a deeper meaning in the same line as that of the author he is commenting on, whether Aristotle or Boethius or another, and he indicates it even though that doctrine assumes a personal interpretation of St. Thomas beyond what that author has explicitly said.

On the other hand, we observe in St. Thomas a great sense of history which leads him to ask for better translations of the classical works of philosophy in order to compare them with one another with the aim of ascertaining the meaning intended by the author in his explanations. For example, he discovers that the "Liber de causis" isn't Aristotle's work but is inspired by the Neo-Platonist Proclus. St. Thomas makes a great effort to know all the previous thought as widely as possible, from the great philosophers of antiquity to the Fathers. In his "Catena aurea" he uses some writings of the Fathers which had been forgotten and he is the first one who uses council documents in theology. Also to be included in the first group are the various "Quaestiones disputatae" and "Quodlibetales", such as "De Veritate", "De potencia", "De malo", "De anima" etc.

In the second group we find a good number of treatises and philosophical and theological opuscules which he was asked to write. Here we find material for preaching, like the commentaries on the "Our Father", the "Hail Mary", the Creed, sermons, prayers, etc. The most important treatises in this group are the "Summa contra Gentiles", requested by the General of his order, St. Raymond of Penafort; and the "Summa Theologiae", the fruit of his concern to facilitate the learning of theology, which was found too widely dispersed in the "Book of Sentences". In summary, the writings of St. Thomas contain mature thought, expounded with clarity and order, without rigidity or improvisations. It is no surprise that the treatises present a very careful editorial work. It is also good to keep in mind that St. Thomas is above all a theologian. Therefore, what is most original in his philosophy is to be found in his systematic works, the "Summae" and "Quaestiones", rather than in his commentaries on Aristotle, and hence in a theological context.

3. Sources of the Philosophy of St. Thomas

St. Thomas respected the previous thought worthy of credit and didn't want to build a brand new philosophical doctrine. Thus we seek the origin of his work of synthesis in traditional sources. A review of his work lets us appreciate his abundant use and deep knowledge of Latin, Greek, Arab and Jewish authors. St. Thomas came into contact with Aristotle in Naples and assimilated his doctrine through the teaching of St. Albert and the translations of William of Moerbeke.

St. Thomas did not choose between Aristotle and the historical Plato but rather made a synthesis of the work of Aristotle and Neo-Platonism. He only knew Plato indirectly and he died before he was able to interpret his doctrine. St. Thomas took the main theses of Aristotle's metaphysics, such as act and potency, the primacy of the singular being, the distinction of substance and accidents and a number of concrete points. But Aristotle has as his central reality the singular substance, and within it the form, while for St. Thomas the "actus essendi", not the form, is the most profound act of things. Here he refers to Plato, accepting his doctrine of participation, for the topic of being. The singular things are beings by participation, and thus depend on a Cause which is Being by essence. He corrects in this way Plato, who had put the separate Forms (Ideas) as principles of things. Aristotle was right in saying that forms are intrinsic to things and can't be substantialized, but he didn't arrive at a radical First Cause of the world. For St. Thomas, that Cause is "Esse Subsistens", which we call God.

St. Thomas also accepts the indisputable authority of St. Augustine, especially in theology, but he is more cautious in philosophical topics. He accepts the doctrine of causal transcendence and divine exemplarism. When he disagrees with him, he shows that he is combating Plotinus or the Arab interpreters instead of St. Augustine. Along with St. Augustine, he is influenced by PsD's "De divinis nominibus" from which he takes a good part of the doctrines on transcendentals, the intensive notion of being, participation, the knowledge of God (affirmative and negative theology), the problem of evil and the doctrine on the cosmological order of the world.

Three other sources of St. Thomas' philosophy - Boëthius, "Liber de causis", and Avicenna - join in suggesting to him the main doctrine of his philosophy, namely the real distinction between essence and "esse" in creatures. From Boëthius he takes also the explanation that the correspondence between the logical and the real orders in the doctrine on universals is a participation. The "Liber de causis" inspired him in elaborating his doctrine that "esse" is the fundamental act of being, and also in going deeper in the doctrine on participation. Finally, the Neo-Platonist Avicenna accompanies all the intellectual work of St. Thomas, though his influence is less in the works of maturity. By correcting Avicenna, St. Thomas gives us the best and most original of his doctrine; for example, the solution of the problem of universals, the distinction in creatures between essence and the act of being, and the distinction between the causes of "fieri" and of "esse", the foundation of his metaphysics of causality. To sum up, to an Aristotelianism conforming with faith as a basis, St. Thomas adds Neo-Platonic elements, having "esse" as the nucleus.

4. Some Important Doctrines of St. Thomas

St. Thomas elaborates a philosophy according to theological needs, based on the observation of real things. Thus he doesn't construct a system in the modern sense by deduction from "a priori" principles. His doctrine arises in harmony with the supernatural truths of Catholic dogma, from which he strives for better comprehension, without adulterating it or replacing it by his own axioms. At the same time, he has in mind what we now call particular sciences, but his perennial doctrine is independent of the state of the sciences of his time. Sometimes in his works we find examples taken from the physics or astronomy of his time, but these points do not affect his philosophy or theology. St. Thomas doesn't defend them nor is he interested in them. He simply receives opinions which he uses in order to give examples, to contribute some argument of fittingness.

At other times he does make metaphysical judgements about them in order to warn about doctrinal errors which could follow from them (like denying human freedom or lessening the causality of God). On the other hand, the work of St. Thomas has a structure, an order and a spirit that is well defined which explains the prestige and authority he has enjoyed for centuries. Technically speaking, the Thomistic metaphysical "corpus" has emerged unscathed in discussions, which often are charged with unscientific prejudices, with idealist or materialist immantentism or with positivism. Without giving here a detailed exposition of his doctrine, which is studied throughout the Biennium, we limit ourselves here to the indication of the most fundamental and original aspects.

a) REASON AND FAITH.

The medieval authors had always recognized the supremacy of faith over reason for the elaboration of their philosophico-theological doctrines. However, this simple relation of order left a broad field of confusion in the manner of dealing with the distinct materials. St. Albert the Great clearly separated the two realms and St. Thomas follows this distinction, making some points more precise in a very interesting manner. First of all, theology is a science and not only some articles of faith which one must believe. His starting point is dogma, whose truths, certified by the authority of God who reveals, supply absolute certainty to reason.

Theological activity consists in obtaining argumentative conclusions, starting with dogma. Theology as a science is subordinate to the knowledge of God and of the blessed, in which we participate by faith. God is the source of all truth, both natural and supernatural. Thus there can exist no conflict between theology and the truth acquired by unaided reason, which is the content of philosophy. Nor is there any obstacle in theology suggesting some points to philosophy so that it can reach them by its own natural way. Theology becomes a positive and a negative norm of philosophy, positive because it moves to investigate, negative because it clearly points out errors. Based on principles taken from experience, philosophy is a useful instrument, a necessary aid in more perfectly contemplating God, who is the last end both of philosophy and of theology. St. Thomas says that philosophy will be recompensed for its service since theology gives many philosophical concepts a higher evidence and sense, though philosophy can also work autonomously.

b) THE NATURAL AND THE SUPERNATURAL ORDERS.

Just as philosophy and theology are distinct sciences united in God, the one source of both, and in the believer without any confusion, there exists analogously a supernatural order, or of grace, and a natural order, both instituted by God, which are ruled by distinct principles and yet merge in man without confusion. The clarity with which St. Thomas expresses this distinction allows him to draw consequences of maximum importance. On the one hand, it implies the distinction between reason and faith. Faith refers to the One and Triune God; the reality of the world allows reason to undertake the task of its comprehension and to be raised to demonstrate the existence of God, and if reason works correctly, it comes to demonstrate the preambles of faith, that is, to know the most important natural truths which dispose it easily to receive and maintain the faith: the existence of God and His nature as One and Perfect; divine creation of the world and the condition as creatures that the things have; the spirituality and immortality of the soul; God as last end of life; the norms of the natural law.

On the other hand, we find divine grace, understood as a gift inhering in the soul by which the whole man is made a participant in divine nature. Augustinian tradition didn't come to be aware of this and remained in the consideration of grace as an extrinsic gift to man. Precisely this Augustinian conception, accepted by nominalism, will be converted with Luther into "extrinsic justification" by faith alone. For St. Thomas, habitual grace interiorly heals the whole man, because it inheres in the soul in a way analogous to how the accident is found in the substance, and since the soul is essentially the substantial co-principle of man, the sanctifying grace accompanying it is the principle or formal cause of justification. In the same way, the infused virtues are supernatural habits which are in the subject, and the sacraments are efficacious instrumental causes of grace, not just preparations or disposing causes for receiving it. Evidently, underlying this argument is St. Thomas' metaphysics.

c) FROM PHILOSOPHY OF NATURE TO METAPHYSICS.

i) The World of Nature. Aristotle makes St. Thomas understand the importance of the immediate or spontaneous knowledge of the natural world - an idea neglected by the Augustinians and Neo-Platonists - according to which it is evident that there exists in the world a multitude of corporeal beings. A first reflection about them allows us to be aware that in one and the same thing changes occur without the thing itself ceasing to be. In this way there arises the distinction between substance and accidents and of accidents from one another. If we pursue this observation, we notice that some substances are converted into others. In this change there is something which remains while one substance disappears and another appears. We call this substrate PRIME MATTER and the element determining the substance FORM.

St. Thomas accepts hylomorphic composition of material substances, understanding prime matter as pure potency, and substantial form as the principle giving a body its specific essence. They are two mutually implied principles. St. Thomas accepts Aristotle’s philosophy of nature, correcting some Platonist deviations. In particular, he had to fight against the theory of the plurality of substantial forms which the Neo-Platonists maintained because of their exaggerated realism.

ii) The Metaphysical Structure of Beings. St. Thomas doesn't limit himself to describe the world of bodies, composed of form and matter. The most central aspect of his philosophy is to analyze things as creatures not only by the fact that they are created by God (transcendental causality) but because their created character is reflected in their intrinsic constitution itself. For St. Thomas, all things are radically ENTIA, subjects which participate in ESSE. The things are composed of act and potency at diverse levels, as all theologians of his time admitted. But the most profound act and the first that there is in each being (ENS) and the root of its perfections (which are such because they are) is the act of being (ESSE), which for St. Thomas is act in the strong sense and not the simple fact of existing. Thus all created things have a real composition of ESSE and essence, which are two constitutive co-principles of any real object. The resultant whole is called ENS, that which has being.

Being (ESSE) is act and essence, together with the accidents, is a receptive potency, a subject which possesses or participates in ESSE. The binomial esse-essence is the key to St. Thomas' metaphysics, that which characterizes all the things of the universe.

Philosophers before St. Thomas had not perceived this clearly and so many only considered that the most central aspect of things is their essence and relegated ESSE to accidental category. This allowed St. Thomas to surpass universal hylomorphism which some Augustinians posited in order to safeguard the difference between God and creatures. For St. Thomas, angels have no

matter at all, they are pure forms but without doubt are finite beings, for these forms participate in esse, they enter into composition with it. Thus the angel doesn't have God's simplicity, that of pure act of being without limit.

Another important aspect of St. Thomas' metaphysics is the relevance that it gives to the concrete being (SUPPOSITUM), or subject or subsistent. The only thing that really exists is that which has being (esse), the individual being (ens). Its essence or nature, its accidents, its relations, etc. are parts of the ENS, they must not be considered as something subsistent, they must not be made into things. Everything comes together in the concrete beings or they vanish, for outside of concrete things there is nothing real. Thus the philosophy of St. Thomas can be considered also as a metaphysics of the concrete, endowed with a maximum value, for it is a frequent defect of many philosophies to deviate to the plane of ideal abstractions.

iii) The Ascent to God, Esse by Essence. St. Thomas begins examining things of the universe by reason and finds that they are finite, that they have being and are not unlimited being. He notices that they participate in esse, in a partial way, and from this he infers rationally the existence of a First Creative Cause, something which up to then no philosopher had done clearly. He argues that if the things have esse by participation, they can't be the causes of their own esse. Thus, this participation in esse requires that these things be caused, and caused in their very being, that is, produced out of nothing. Only a Being which is Esse Itself can do this. Thus, for St. Thomas God's most proper name is He Who Is. His 5 ways are diverse modes of ascending to God beginning with creatures. In them he considers aspects of the world which show its ontological insufficiency in order to arrive to God.

d) MAN.

The philosophical anthropology of St. Thomas is based on the consideration of the structure of man as a composite of body and soul which together make up the unity of a single person. The human soul is the form of the body but at the same time it is a spiritual substance, capable of subsisting by itself in being, as something independent of the body. The spiritual condition of the human soul, however, is not opposed to the unity of the complete man, but rather guarantees it even more, for the soul informs the whole body and communicates to it being and substantiality. The spirituality of the human soul is known because of the complete immateriality of its operations of intellect and will. The spirituality consists precisely in the fact that the soul is not limited to being simply a form or act of the corporeal matter, but goes beyond this function and is a true substance, i.e., a form which has "esse" in itself, as opposed to the forms of the other natural bodies which have "esse" only in union with matter. Thus the human soul does not come from matter nor is it educed from a body but it is created by God immediately, who infuses it into the body generated by the parents.

In this way, St. Thomas overcomes the difficulties of pure Aristotelianism which didn't see how the form of a body could be immortal; and he also surpasses Platonism which, on insisting on the spirituality of human souls, didn't explain the substantial union with the body. In the metaphysical psychology of St. Thomas there are details and profound analyses of the potencies of the human soul and its activity, the passions, and very much stressed is the mark of person which all individuals of rational nature have. This is a logical consequence of the insistence of St. Thomas on the "suppositum". In his study of human operations St. Thomas gives particular importance to the primacy of freedom, in the face of the excessive intellectualism of Neo-Platonist doctrines and of Aristotle himself. Arab philosophy also subjected man to the

necessary influence of the stars and of separate intellects. For St. Thomas, human conduct is free, thanks to the will, a potency whereby we act with self-determination in the order to an end. The will is the power by which man moves himself, by putting into act his potencies, in intimate union with the intellect but with dominion even over it in the order of exercise.

Furthermore, St. Thomas situates human freedom principally before God as the last end. Free choice is the capacity which man has in this life to choose his own last end and the means leading to it, a capacity which is actualized in the moment of choice. But since our freedom is imperfect, there is the possibility of choosing evil, the will being able to refuse to love God above all things in order to prefer the created good as last end, a choice which constitutes the very essence of sin.

e) KNOWLEDGE.

Intellect and Senses. The immediate principle of human knowledge according to St. Thomas is the faculty of the soul that we call intellect, and not divine illumination, as the Augustinians said, nor a higher and impersonal Intellect as the Averroists thought. If one wants to be more precise one must say with St. Thomas that the intellect is a participation of the divine light in us and it must be understood as a power or capacity of knowing in its purest form. At the start, the intellect is empty, "tabula rasa", without content and without innate ideas. With time and by induction from experience, the intellect acquires the first principles of being and of operation. The whole person and all his powers intervene in the operation of knowing. The most notable characteristic of Thomist gnoseology is the union that it maintains between intelligible operation and sense activity, a point which the Neo-Platonists neglected.

This is in conformity with the doctrine of the substantial union of the soul with the body. Human understanding of things is produced by means of the senses, according to a double movement. First of all, the intellect obtains, through sense perception, abstract and universal knowledge. Secondly, the intellect refers the universals to the concrete things, returning to the experience from which it had begun, thus reaching its proper object, the "quidditas" or the nature existing in matter. Consequently, an intellectual knowledge of singular things is produced, something that the nominalists of later centuries will not understand, thanks to the continuation of the intellect in sensitive knowledge. This continuation becomes effective especially through the function of the cogitative or particular reason, which is a sensitive cognoscitive power, though it is rational by participation. St. Thomas lays special emphasis on this faculty, which serves as a bridge uniting abstract thought with the concrete experiences of life.

Starting with this basis, St. Thomas explains that human intellectual knowledge can have three fundamental objects: the external things, the soul itself, and God. The first and most adequate knowledge of the soul in union with the body is the knowledge of sensible things external to ourselves. This takes place according to the process which we have indicated above. Self-knowledge is that which man has of the interior acts of his spirit. For St. Thomas, the intellect

has the property of reflecting on its own acts. Self-knowledge is produced after the intellect has entered into contact with the external world, and not before. Through it the soul explores its own inner state, its acts and its nature. It is knowledge of great importance, for through it man is aware of the morality of his acts. This is moral conscience.

For St. Thomas, the natural knowledge of God follows from the contemplation of natural things and has the mark of analogy. He makes ample use of analogy in all his metaphysics and affirms that it is a property of some concepts which are applied to diverse realities in diverse ways, as far distant from equivocity as from univocity. For example, "ens" is not said in the same way of God as of the creatures, the accidents, etc. According to St. Thomas, effects are similar to their causes, because a cause can only transmit its own perfections. Thus it is natural for the world to be a likeness of God, even though there is a disproportion between the Exemplary Cause and the creatures. Hence we can form a certain idea of God, an analogous concept of His Perfection, based on the perfections we observe in things.

Here St. Thomas takes especially the doctrine of PsD. The world has limited and graduated perfections. We must purify them of all imperfections, then affirm them in God and deny that God has these perfections as deficiently as we conceive them and as they are found in creatures. Finally we must attribute them to God in a supereminent way. Thus we say that God is Subsistent Being.

f) ETHICS.

The moral teaching of St. Thomas comes as a consequence of his metaphysics. If God is the supreme Principle of the universe, which in its turn is a participated reflection of His perfections, then logically the universe has no other sense than that of giving glory to God. The last and transcendental end of the world is to be like God. But the free spiritual creatures are ordered to this same last end in a higher way. God has created them to know Him and to love Him forever. St. Thomas brings up in this point the ethical elements of Aristotle, by elaborating a moral doctrine which expresses the natural order of things, that is, that is not purely supernatural. (In his theological works St. Thomas studies the supernatural order). Aristotle had said only that man tends to happiness, which is ordered to the good in general, without being more precise. St. Thomas affirms that if the good follows from the being of the things, logically the ESSE SUBSISTENS is the Highest Good and therefore the Last End to which all creatures aspire by nature, even though they might not know it. Hence sin is the greatest transgression against the very structure of the nature of things, and thus it is natural that the consequence of sin is the loss of happiness for man.

The ordination to God assumes, however, that man must live an order also in his relations with things, with his fellow men and with himself. Thus St. Thomas shows that the various commandments of the Decalogue, which impose various virtues, are consequences of the fundamental precept of the love for God above all things. The natural moral law is the ordination of human acts to their due end. It is like the measure or rule to which human conduct must submit itself in order to arrive at the end. For St. Thomas the moral law exists above all in God as Supreme Legislator (Eternal Law), but it also exists in rational creatures in a participated way (natural law). In fact, the moral law is impressed in human hearts and man can know it by the light of his reason, if it is upright and has not been weakened. It is not a question of divine illumination nor of the possession of innate ideas (Augustinianism), but rather it is known starting with the experience that man has of his acts.

Finally, let us point out that the natural ethics of St. Thomas also has as a fundamental tenet that the temporal life of man is on the way to eternal life, to the moment in which man reaches God as last end or loses Him definitively. Natural reason makes us aware that God is a Rewarder who will reward the just and punish those who do evil and that this will happen permanently at the time that the soul is separated from the body. Naturally, about these points we have many more lights thanks to Revelation. In the works of St. Thomas the philosophical considerations are intimately united with the strictly theological explanation which is realized beginning with faith.

5. Doctrinal Authority of Thomist Philosophy Recognized by the Magisterium of the Church

The penetration of the doctrine of St. Thomas in the intellectual life of Europe begins with his canonization by John XXII in 1323 which removes any suspicion about undue or dangerous assimilation of Aristotelian philosophy for the faith. Since that time and for the next seven centuries the Church, in the exercise of her Magisterium, has not ceased to indicate that the theological and philosophical doctrine of St. Thomas is the most certain and most in conformity with Revelation. In modern times, the Church has insistently recommended that St. Thomas be followed as a means to overcome the immanentist basis of many modern philosophers who subvert and nullify the contents of the Catholic faith.

The encyclical "Aeterni Patris" of Leo XIII, dated 4th August 1879, can be considered as a return to Thomist sources in the face of the doctrinal confusion which was infiltrating among Catholics. It was seconded by the creation, in 1879, of the Academy of St. Thomas and by the preparation of a critical edition of all his works. In 1880 Leo XIII proclaimed St. Thomas patron of Catholic schools. His successor, St. Pius X, insisted repeatedly on the need of a direct study of the works of St. Thomas, indicating the importance of following him especially in questions of metaphysics. A set of the 24 most important theses of St. Thomas was published in the first days of the pontificate of Benedict XV. Pius XI and Pius XII also insist on the importance of following the method and spirit of St. Thomas in the teaching of philosophy and theology in all ecclesiastical centres. The same idea is contained in the Decree "Optatam Totius" of Vatican II. Paul VI and John Paul II have also taught along the same line.

6. Reactions to Thomism. First Followers of his Doctrine

If we examine attentively the doctrine of St. Thomas, we notice immediately that it affects the whole field of theology and philosophy in a way which was completely new for his time. The two "scandalous" theses of St. Thomas are the unicity of the substantial form, and the real distinction between "esse" and essence, which some were not able to understand. Thus, it could appear that St. Thomas made common cause with the Averroist Aristotelianism of the Faculty of Arts in Paris, and he was considered as having been included in the condemnations of 1270 and 1277. However, his doctrine was not in the field in which it was thought to be combated, and the polemic redounded to his benefit. Perhaps at the insistence of St. Albert the Great, the General Chapters of the Dominican Order, from 1278, insistently invited its members to study the doctrine and the writings of St. Thomas, and so very soon it found welcome among the Dominicans as well as among the secular clergy and some Franciscans who abandoned the Augustinian tradition.

More than a century and a half would pass before disciples appear who faithfully follow St. Thomas in the greater part of his doctrine, but by then what we call "Thomism" had already crystallized, that is, that philosophical tradition which defends theses of St. Thomas, the fruit of a polemic with Franciscanism which lasted more than 50 years. Thus, from the first moment, it would suffice to defend one single thesis of St. Thomas in order to be considered "Thomist". This is the case of Giles (Aegidius) of Rome (1247-1313), who for three years was a student of St. Thomas in Paris and later became General of the Order of Augustinian Hermits. He left behind a doctrine which is quite different from that of St. Thomas except regarding the real distinction between essence and "esse" which he vigorously defended against Henry of Ghent. At any rate, in two of his works he gives a very personal interpretation of this real distinction. With new terminology, he speaks of "esse essentiae" and "esse existentiae", that is, he conceives essence and existence as two different things.

Moreover, he already begins to translate the "esse" of St. Thomas as "existentia", thus losing its character of act. This interpretation differs completely from the doctrine of St. Thomas, for whom "esse" is really distinct from essence of which it is act, just as it is distinct from the act which is form with respect to matter. Moreover, the act of "esse" and the essence are entitative co-principles which can't exist separately although they are really distinct from one another. Giles of Rome understood the "esse"-act of St. Thomas as "esse"-form, due to his reading of Proclus and Boëthius.

Consequently he made the principles of "ens" into things, an error which many beginners in the study of St. Thomas are prone to. Thus, it isn't enough that an author profess that he follows St. Thomas, in order truly to be a Thomist.

7. Henry of Ghent (+1293)

In the midst of the growing prestige of the professors of the religious and the mendicant orders in the Universities of Paris and of Oxford, the figure of Henry of Ghent stands out. He was a secular priest who enjoyed great authority during the last quarter of the 13th century. He was Master of Theology in Paris from 1276 to 1292 and advisor of Stephen Tempier in the condemnations of 1277. He was a protagonist in the controversy on the real distinction between essence and "esse" against the "Thomists" up to the point of giving the impression that this was the only important problem. Henry of Ghent is usually considered as an independent philosopher, rather eclectic but with a certain originality. Above all, it is indispensable to know him in order to understand the way in which Duns Scotus, on whom he exercised great influence, will posit problems. Although at times Henry accepts Aristotelian doctrines, such as the unicity of the substantial form, in later works he corrects himself in an Augustinian sense, perhaps because he thinks that Thomism is a dangerous invasion of pagan philosophy. This rejection will bring him close to Avicenna and St. Augustine.

He begins his discussions by asking that if essence and existence are distinct, what is existence or "esse"? Since it seems, according to common opinion, that everyone agrees that "esse" is neither substance nor accident, then it appears that it is not really distinct from essence. On the other hand, the concepts of essence and existence do not have the same content, for it seems that the second adds something to essence. Thus he says that the distinction between essence and existence is purely intentional in creatures, because the essence relates the creature with God as exemplary cause, and existence relates the creature with God as efficient cause. That is to say, that essence and "esse" only indicate a distinct relations of dependence of the creature with God according to our way of understanding, but they are not really distinct in the "ens".

In order to understand the metaphysics of Henry of Ghent, we must place ourselves in the scheme of thought of Avicenna. For Avicenna, metaphysics is the science of "ens" as "ens", but considering that "ens" encompasses the division between necessary being and contingent or possible beings. Henry of Ghent begins with this notion of "ens" and in order not to fall into the Neo-Platonic necessarianism of Avicenna, instead of dividing "ens" into necessary and possible, he distinguishes it analogously. There is "something which is being itself", which is God; and there is "something to which it is fitting or can be naturally fitting to be", or all the other beings. Consequently, the notion of "ens" is predicated in an analogous way of God and of creatures, but it cannot signify the two at the same time, but rather one or the other. The idea of "ens" is evidently applied first of all to God, "ens per se", in Whom essence is identified with existence.

Since God is the first being that is, He will be the first in man's knowledge ("primum cognitum") and the reason of knowledge ("ratio cognoscendi") of all the other beings. This notion of "ens" then suffices in order to demonstrate the existence of God. Therefore, the "a posteriori" proofs which begin with the sense world are unnecessary, though valid.

Returning to creatures, it is clear that their actual existence depends on the divine Will, and from this point of view there can be a distinction from the essence, but from the moment in which creatures exist, that real distinction has no meaning.

Finally, in order to explain creation Henry has recourse to the double dependence of the creature on the Creator mentioned above. The essence of every (possible) thing has its corresponding exemplary or divine idea. These ideas are in God, but they represent the creatures as distinct from God, in such a way that the divine ideas contain the "esse essentiae" or the "ideatum" of all things. God knows His essence and, in it, all possible creatures, but He knows them as already distinct from His own essence and therefore with their own proper being. On the other hand, the divine Will freely grants, when He wants, existence to those possible beings. Creation consists precisely in this. In the face of the problem of how God knows the creatures that He has already created, since He knows all the possible beings in His own essence, Henry responds that the divine Intellect knows their existence in the very act of creating.

SUMMARY OF HISTORY OF MEDIEVAL PHILOSOPHY

IX. Philosophy in the 14th Century

1. John Duns Scotus (1266-1308)

The last great Scholastic philosopher is John Duns Scotus, native of Scotland. He became a Franciscan at the age of 15 and was ordained priest 10 years later. From 1297 he taught in Oxford, moving to Paris in 1301. Shortly before he died, he was destined to Cologne. He published nothing in his life, but left behind a large collection of manuscripts, among them two commentaries on the "Book of Sentences" as well as several other works.

a) Philosophy and Theology

For Duns Scotus, the field proper to philosophy is limited with respect to theology. The latter has as its object God as God, whereas metaphysics, as the highest part of philosophy, is concerned with being as being. For this reason, metaphysics cannot reach God in Himself, just as theology teaches.

In fact, history shows that reason has never been able to reach the Trinitarian dogma, nor the concept of creation, nor the definition "God is Love" which Holy Scripture gives us. If from above metaphysics is limited by theology, from below it is limited by the nature of our knowledge, which is precarious since it begins with the sensitive (as Aristotle says) and consequently can never give a concept of immaterial beings, such as angels or God. Metaphysics will be possible if it succeeds in starting from an idea of "ens" which is so abstract and indeterminate that it can be applied indiscriminately to everything in the same sense. Duns Scotus finds this notion on considering "ens" as opposed to "nothing".

The very first thing that appears in this opposition is that "ens" is "ens", and this fact is common to infinite and to finite being, to material and to immaterial. Thus the notion of "ens univocum" arises, which corresponds to "ens" before any specification, even that of existence. The "ens univocum" is neither a physical reality, nor a universal concept, but rather the very "nature" of "ens" as "ens", because of which it can be predicated of everything. Consequently, the "ens univocum" of Duns Scotus looks like the logical universal and will be the form of all possible forms which is emptiest of content. Of course, from such a notion it is impossible to obtain any real knowledge.

The first intrinsic property of "ens" as "ens" is that which permits considering its modifications, that is, establishing the division between finite and infinite. This division comes before the division of being according to the 10 Aristotelian categories. Thus, reason is circumscribed to the sphere of the demonstrable. What cannot be demonstrated becomes object of theology. Duns Scotus expresses this opinion very clearly: Nothing that is demonstrable is revealed by God, and nothing that is revealed is demonstrable unless it comes from Revelation. And so, the way is opened that leads in the 16th century to the complete separation of metaphysics from theology. Duns Scotus works with the same philosophical terms as St. Thomas, but he understands them almost always in a different way. Like St. Thomas, he knows that the intellect elaborates concepts from experience, but on beginning to reason, he will make a turn that is not small.

For St. Thomas, based always on sense evidence, a universal concept expresses the very essence of things, because it is bound indirectly but immediately to experience. On the contrary, Duns Scotus, without denying this, in order to reason fixes his attention on concepts already formed and on necessary relations among them, omitting further sense evidence. For example, in the demonstration of the existence of God, St. Thomas always starts with sense observation, and Duns Scotus with the contents of the concept. In summary, the work of Duns Scotus becomes a critique, in the name of theology, of the possibilities of metaphysics, for he refers to theology

for important points of metaphysics. Now this theology isn't speculative, but rather a practical science which regulates our actions, even the exercise of thought ordered to happiness.

b) The Knowledge of God

Another central point in the philosophy of Duns Scotus is the almost exclusive value he gives to "a priori" demonstrations. St. Thomas recognized the fundamental demonstrative value of "a posteriori" arguments which go from effect to cause and made good use of them in his 5 ways. On the contrary, Duns Scotus puts all his attention in "a priori" proofs, because if they exist, the others follow necessarily. Thus he maintains that demonstrations from effect to cause, though valid, don't even deserve that name and have only a relative value. This turn, only apparently small, will substantially modify the proof of the existence of God, the doctrine on divine attributes and the soul, etc.

In order to demonstrate the existence of God, one can't start with sensible beings, because along this way one only arrives (with Aristotle) at the first mover or first cause, without transcending the physical world of nature. Nor should one, says Duns, recur to theology for the definition of God, as St. Anselm did. Thus, the only starting point is the notion of univocal being. We can use it because this notion suggests immediately the need of establishing something first in the order of being, in relation to which everything else can be explained. Since it's not a question of postulating God's existence in the name of intellectual necessity, it is above all necessary to prove the possibility of the existence of a first cause and then demonstrate its existence.

The first cause is possible because there is no other cause which can impede its existence and hence it is possible by itself. Therefore it cannot not exist. But the possibility of any other cause doesn't necessarily imply its existence since it can be impeded by a higher cause. So whatever excludes any cause with respect to its being cannot not exist. Hence, since the first being is possible, it necessarily exists. For identical motives, the first being is infinite, for nothing limits it and thus it enjoys all perfections in highest degree since it is first in all of them. God is one, infinite, wise, good, etc. But for Duns Scotus another series of divine attributes can't be proven "a priori" nor "a posteriori": Omnipotence, Providence, Truth, etc. which are known only by faith, and the same thing occurs with the immortality of the soul.

c) God and Creatures

Duns Scotus realized he had just demonstrated the existence of the necessary Being in a way analogous to that of Avicenna and thus could fall with him into the error of explaining creation as an obligatory emanation of the necessary Being in the mode of Greek necessitarianism. Moreover, his notion of univocal being erased the boundaries between necessary being and contingent beings. In these conditions he had to take a radical decision: to speak of the dominion of divine Freedom as cause of contingent beings.

According to Duns Scotus, God creates what He wants, when He wants and because He wants and all creatures are contingent. Let it not be thought, however, that God is arbitrary. In fact,

His Will can create what He wants, this world or another, etc., but once done, that is converted into immutable law, in such way that whatever follows cannot contradict it. The same occurs in the moral order. God could have established other laws distinct from the present ones, which also would be correct because they come from His Will. The only thing that He could not change are the first two precepts of the Decalogue for He is bound to them. Outside of these two restrictions, nothing limits the freedom of God. He is not even conditioned in creation by the knowledge He has of all things in His infinite essence. Therefore, the only cause for which God wanted things is His Will.

Duns Scotus could not go farther in his voluntarism. If he does not fall into Cartesianism, it's because he still distinguishes clearly between the divine Intellect and the divine Will. To sum it up, for Duns Scotus, creation doesn't depend on the Wisdom of God, it doesn't have intrinsic necessary laws, but it is as it is by pure Will of God. For St. Thomas, on the contrary, creation has elements of necessity, given the free and creative Will of God.

d) The Principle of Individuation

In order to explain the essence of purely contingent beings, Duns Scotus rejects the real distinction between essence and "esse", which seems false to him. He accepts the doctrine of universal hylomorphism, taking up again in a very peculiar way the ancient doctrine of the plurality of forms. Since the mission of matter is to receive the form, logically matter will exist first. This is perfectly possible on the part of divine Omnipotence. The composite of matter and form (essence) possesses a reality of such character that it is possible to observe "formalities" in it.

In order to understand what these are, one must refer back to the theory of "formal distinction". The Scotist formal distinction is intermediate between the real distinction and that of reason, but it is not to be confused with the distinction of reason "cum fundamento in re". There is a formal distinction every time that the intellect can conceive in a being one of the formal constitutive principles apart from the other, for example the corporeality and the spirituality of man. These formal constitutive principles are the formalities, which are not the logical universal, but rather something of more entity because they are indifferent with respect to the individual and to the universal. Nevertheless, they contain both virtually, as for example, the formality "horse" is not of itself a universal, for otherwise no particular horses would exist. Nor is it a singular, in which case there would be only one horse. In itself, "horse" contains both possibilities.

The realism of matter and form brings as a consequence that the essence has for Duns Scotus more autonomous consistency than in the case of St. Thomas, for whom the essence is fundamentally potency with respect to act. But Scotus gives to understand the existence of a "nature" or essence which is common to several beings. Then, in order to explain the singular being he resorts to a new act or individualizing determination which he calls "haecceitas" (thisness). For example, the person Socrates is the general form of man plus "Socratesness". Since "haecceitas" is the ultimate founding act of the individual concrete being, we must ask what relations it has with the general form. If we assign it an exclusive role, difficulties arise: for example, how can the unity of the human race be safeguarded and, in this case, how can theology explain that Jesus redeemed all men, or how to explain that there is knowledge of natural things, if what exists are individual beings with nothing in common.

The answer of Duns Scotus is that among these forms a formal distinction mediates. Also among the diverse "haecceitas" of the same species is found a formal distinction, that is, a

distinction lower than real, but higher than that of reason. Naturally this is the only solution at hand if one wants to safeguard the unity of the human species and that of all the other species.

e) Balance

Duns Scotus could have followed Alexander of Hales or St. Bonaventure, great masters of his order, or even St. Thomas, but he preferred to correct the first Thomists with Augustinian doctrines. Thus, by keeping the Aristotelian vocabulary and technique, he somehow retrogressed to before St. Augustine in so far as he arrives at a more methodical Platonism in which the logical plane predominates over the ontological plane. To illustrate this point briefly, it suffices to say that on his going back to the absolute divine freedom to create or not, he overcame necessitarianism in the order of being, but not in the order of knowing. In fact, knowledge follows essence and hence it turns out that, starting with the notion of univocal being, it is the same as affirming the existence of an indeterminate essence (Avicenna's "natura communis"). Duns Scotus always moves on this plane. From this viewpoint, evil is an essence and not a privation of due being (St. Augustine). Therefore Scotus could not prove the Omnipotence of God since that would be equivalent to saying that God is the cause of evil, and this was inadmissible for Duns Scotus.

2. William of Ockham (1300?-1350)

More responsible than Duns Scotus for the new routes of philosophy in the 14th century is William of Ockham. Born in England, he was already a Franciscan when he studied in Oxford from 1312 to 1318 and there he remained until 1320 when he was called to Avignon in order to justify his philosophical and theological doctrines, some of which were later condemned as heretical. About 1327, he joined in the ranks of those who opposed the temporal powers of the Papacy, writing doctrines similar to those of Marsilius of Padua (+1342), and for this he had to seek refuge in the court of Emperor Ludwig of Bavaria. He died, probably of the black plague, in Munich around 1350. His philosophical doctrine is found in his writings on the logic and the physics of Aristotle and principally in his commentaries on the Sentences and in two other works. Taken as a whole, it can be characterized as a radical empiricism which will provoke the fall of Scholastic philosophy long before the arrival of modern philosophy.

a) The Starting Point

Ockham considers that the philosophers have wasted too much time seeking sure or certain demonstrations of things, when there is a most clear and universal argument: the immediate evidence. To prove that an affirmation is certain is to show that it is immediately evident or that

it is deduced from something immediately evident. His zeal for the concrete will lead him to identify immediate evidence with sense experience. He says: "Intuitive knowledge is that in virtue of which we know that a thing is when it is, and that it is not when it is not." This can also be expressed in another way: Direct experience of the existence of a thing is the only guarantee that it exists.

Ockham will never yield in this principle, not even in order to explain causality. One can not affirm that an effect proceeds from a cause if this is not experienced, reasoning with the presence and absence of the diverse factors in the event. Consequently, intuitive knowledge is the beginning of experimental knowledge, which is the only thing evident. On the contrary, abstract knowledge is concerned with ideas or concepts, which arise from the trace that experiences leave in the intellect. Nevertheless, although it may find in them the existence of necessary relations, it can never assure that they correspond to real things. It's as if he were to say that in order to build a wall, the bricks must be supported on the ground, adding that all the bricks must always be on the ground, for otherwise no one can assure that they are well supported. It seems, then, that in this way no one will be able to build. Precisely this is what he is going to say in his theory of knowledge.

b) Theory of Knowledge

Ockham is concerned with closely related topics: the universals, in which he claims to be the first one who doesn't grant them any reality at all; and the nature of the knowing process.

i) The Universals. Ockham centres all of his attention on particular beings since there is no reality other than the singular or individual, as experience testifies. It is absurd for the universal to correspond to anything in reality, for if it is something multiple, how can it be one? If it is one, how can it be distributed in many? He explains that in order to speak or to have knowledge, we use terms or words which sometimes represent concepts and sometimes things. Logic teaches that the function of words is to take the place of objects (this function is called "suppositio"). We can distinguish two kinds: "suppositio personalis", which is when the term replaces the real individual; and "suppositio simplex" when the term means something common to many individuals. In the first case, the term refers to an individual, which can be immediately experienced; in the second case, it refers to the universal. It is of interest to metaphysics to ascertain to what reality the second case corresponds. Since what is real is precisely individual, the universal can signify nothing concrete and real except the pure and simple collectivity of individuals and nothing else.

To sum up: the universal does not express anything that exists in reality and since it exists, its place can only be in thought. What reality do universals have in thought? The same that the individuals have which are assigned by the word or term. Sometimes, the terms designate a concept. This occurs when we want to signify objects which are known in a confused manner,

that is, when the intellect isn't able to distinguish several objects among themselves. Thus the universals are words chosen arbitrarily to designate several things which are known in a more or less confused way. Ockham uses genera and species (universals) because in his opinion individuals lend themselves to be classified, but not because these universals signify a nature common to all of them. With this, he leaves the question unanswered.

ii) The Knowing Process. Philosophers have always said that in order to know it is necessary to have a subject and an object. Nevertheless, Ockham says, when he explains how in the act of knowing the sensible (object) and the spiritual (intellect) are related to one another, that philosophers usually insert some intermediate realities, such as impressed species, "verbum mentis", etc., without realizing that in each step they are making a leap from the material to the spiritual.

Under these conditions, he attempts to confront radically the problem of entry, keeping in mind that experience does not show the existence of these intermediate realities and therefore no argument can demonstrate the need of a cause whose reality is not given by experience. In order to actualize the intellect or explain the assimilation of the object, it isn't necessary to admit intermediaries, just as there are none between fire and light or agent and patient. Hence the subject immediately knows the object. Thus, by the action of individual things, there are produced in the intellect some confused sensible images of similar things. From this arises the indeterminate idea of universal.

c) Dissolution of Metaphysics and of Psychology

If the only method of valid demonstration is sense evidence, one understands that little or nothing can be done in natural theology. For Ockham it is not possible to prove the existence of God by means of change, since the principle that nothing is moved unless moved by another is not evident in itself. It seems that it is fulfilled in many cases, but not in others. In fact, there are things which move themselves, like angels or men. Moreover, the existence of an infinite series of motor causes is not impossible. Analogously, there are also no conclusive proofs that God is one, though that seems the most probable. However, there could be several worlds and several Gods, but this cannot be proven.

The same thing occurs if we want to demonstrate that God is infinite, omnipotent, etc. Consequently there is no motive to speak of divine attributes or of establishing an order among them. In reality, it is a question of simple names which we apply to the divine Essence beginning with its effects. Nor can we say that they signify distinct realities. Faithful to his criterion, Ockham now dismantles psychology. In the same way that there is external intuition, there is also internal intuition in man, by which the states of soul, wanting and knowing, are discovered. But this internal intuition does not teach how one knows nor how the will is determined to operate. Hence, we cannot refer back to a substantial and immaterial soul. Therefore, we cannot demonstrate philosophically the immortality of the soul.

d) Ethics

Duns Scotus had arrived at the conclusion that the divine Will was only limited by the principle of non-contradiction and that in His Will ethics finds its foundation. Thus, things are good because God orders them. It is not certain that God orders things to operate which in themselves

are not good. For Scotus, the whole moral law depends on the pure Will of God, except the first and second commandments which refer to God Himself. But Ockham is much more radical. He affirms that the divine Will is not conditioned even by what Scotus says, so that God could have commanded us to hate Him and make that this would be good. In other words, the goodness or malice of human actions is rooted exclusively in obedience or disobedience to God's Will, understood as apart from His Intellect and His Being.

Thus, human acts aren't intrinsically good or evil, and God doesn't command that we do good and avoid evil, but simply that we obey Him. Hence it is also that there are no meritorious acts and so God could condemn the good and save the guilty. Perhaps Ockham, like Scotus before him, had arrived at these conclusions through his effort to stress the divine transcendence and the poverty of the contingent. However, this exasperation of divine transcendence is apparent, for God is lowered to the category of a capricious being deprived of the perfections of His Wisdom and His Being. An ethics in which man claims to obey God without wanting to understand Him in anything is very close to subjectivism. One must not be surprised the Ockham's morals had great repercussions in Luther.

e) Balance and Influence

Ockham isn't very original in his principles, for two currents of thought come together in him: Abelard's nominalism, always present since the 12th century; and the doctrine of the absolute supremacy of divine freedom, developed as a reaction to the Greco-Arab determinism or necessitarianism. What is original in him is the combination of both, since he converts nominalism into the instrument to fight against speculative philosophy and all who seem to him to be connected with it, such as the grand syntheses of the 13th century and that of Duns Scotus. The viewpoint from which Ockham considers things is that of divine Omnipotence, and he eliminates all obstacles which could signify its limitation. In this, he is more radical than Scotus who had already said that divine ideas (or God's knowledge of things in His own essence) cannot influence the Will of the Creator. Ockham adds that if one acknowledges that the divine ideas have no influence, it is preferable to economize concepts and simply affirm that they don't exist.

In these conditions, in face of the powerful divine Will, everything else is radically contingent; that is, beings and our knowledge have a very precarious consistency. It can be no surprise, then, that he says that it suffices that two things be distinct so that God can make one to exist without the other and consequently that all our knowledge about the relations among things is simply doubtful. Even sense intuition itself, the only basis of knowledge, doesn't guarantee the existence of its objects, for God can arouse it without the presence of the object. The result of this doctrine is, on the one hand, that theology can find no support on destroyed metaphysics and finds itself obliged to be enclosed on itself. Since speculative reflection tends little by little to disappear in theological work, in fact it will become a simple collecting of data from Revelation (positive theology) without wanting to understand them.

In its turn, philosophy only reaches a probable knowledge of things, which is in practice a scepticism very close to the anti-philosophical pessimism which will follow Ockham. This will bring with it the profound decadence of metaphysics. On the other hand, the philosophical scepticism of Ockham wants to be compensated by fideism in theology. Thus a more and more unbridgeable abyss is opened between reason and faith. With St. Thomas and the masters of the

13th century, metaphysics had come to explain, by way of natural reason, a nucleus of truths about God. With Duns Scotus the nucleus was reduced quite a bit, but still it was known that God is One, Infinite and Creator. Nothing of this remains in William of Ockham, and there is nothing else to do but embrace these truths with blind faith. Only one more step is needed for the rupture between reason and faith to be complete.

3. The Ockhamist Tendency of the 14th Century

Ockham's doctrines were quickly accepted among very diverse groups of people. Very soon they were called nominalists or terminists and above all "moderni", as opposed to the followers of St. Thomas and of Duns Scotus, who were called "antiqui" and realists. Ockham's ideas took root especially in the Faculty of Arts of Paris and continued being spread in spite of the Church's condemnation of their heretical errors. In 1347 the complete council of the University of Paris met in order to dismiss Nicholas of Autrecourt (+1350) and to witness the burning of his works. Nicholas, with the doctrine received from Ockham, had run through and invalidated all the philosophy of nature of Aristotle and had applied his own conclusions to theology.

The first principle of his philosophy is that of sense evidence, which can have two sources: experimental verification and the principle of identity, which can be reduced to that of non-contradiction. The fundamental criterion of truth, the principle of non-contradiction, states that contradictories can't be simultaneously true. If this principle is applied to causality, it turns out that, beginning with the fact that a thing exists, one cannot deduce that another thing exists. Moreover, one can only speak of causality when effect and cause are seen at the same time. Consequently, the existence of God can't be deduced from the world's existence nor can it be demonstrated that the world would not exist if God did not exist.

What then is substance, for we speak of it when a determined number of events occur around a thing? Experience tells us nothing about its existence but only shows us accidents. Therefore, the rule cannot be true: "every accident supposes a substance." It is really a question of a particular case of the impossibility of applying the principle of causality. Not even in this case are cause and effect, substance and accident, seen simultaneously. In other words, the phrase "every accident supposes a substance" is a tautology, coming from the principle of identity. Analogously one can proceed for the perfection and end of beings. If we say that one thing is the end of another, we attribute to the effect a cause which is separated, which is not evident. In order to verify that one thing is more perfect than another, two different things must be compared. This is the reality that we find; namely, that they are distinct and equally different. Certainly, each one of them contributes, according to its nature, to the perfection and harmony of the whole. But if they are equally different, they will also be just as perfect. Thus, to try to make a hierarchy is arbitrary.

On the other hand, Nicholas has a very strange idea about experience. He says that from the fact that an event now occurs, it doesn't follow that it will be repeated, even under the same

conditions. Thus, if the hand is burned by fire, we don't know if this will occur again if the hand touches fire. Once the notion of causality is thus undone, Nicholas embraces Epicurean atomism, which says that everything is made of atoms and all change consists in local movement of atoms. From this position he affirms that intellect and senses of a dead person could return to action if the atoms return to the same combination as in the living body, deducing from this strange theories about rewards and punishments in eternal life.

In another direction, this atmosphere of philosophical scepticism comes indirectly to be an auxiliary factor in scientific investigation, not because it contributes a method or material or interest in this task, but rather because it was creating an intellectual atmosphere in which scientific results were finding echo and understanding. The concerns of thinkers in the 12th and 13th centuries moved in the sphere of logic, metaphysics, theory of knowledge, etc. The study of experimental sciences was considered to be inferior and aroused less interest. On the contrary, in conformity with the acceptance of the fact that the only authentic knowledge comes from sense evidence, the hour arrived in which the scientists of the Faculty of Arts of Paris, like John Buridan and his disciple Albert of Saxony, took charge of the rectorate of the university.

Thus, the 14th century is an age of gradual progress in natural sciences, by means of observations, analyses, etc., though many of the discoveries were not fruitfully utilized until they were accepted by the new physics of the 16th and 17th centuries. As examples we can cite the explanation of uniformly accelerated motion, gravity, the co-ordinates, reasoned hypotheses of heliocentrism, which fell into oblivion and which the new physics would have to rediscover.

4. Other Authors of the 14th Century

In 1322 Peter Aureolus, the Franciscan and Master of Theology in Paris, died, leaving behind his "Tractatus de principiis" and a commentary on the Sentences. In his books he criticizes the majority of theologians and philosophers who preceded him, like St. Bonaventure, St. Thomas and Duns Scotus. With Aristotle he maintains that matter has no actuality without form, and inversely, with Averroes he says that the form can neither exist nor be conceived without matter. With this assumption, he can't understand the definition of the Council of Vienne that the rational soul is truly and in itself the form of the body. For Aureolus form is act of matter and therefore incapable of thinking (like that of a stone). Moreover, the form is born and dies with the body, and so its immortality is not explained. However, that conciliar definition must be accepted without restrictions only by faith, without trying to understand it. In these conditions it becomes very difficult to explain knowledge, for his concept of form hinders it, but experience shows that knowledge exists.

Thus he affirms simply that in the knowing subject there is a union between the imaginable and the intellect. He attributes to the imagination the role of grasping reality. There is neither impressed nor expressed species, neither empirical nor intellectual, and this can be maintained with two more reasons: that all the elements that philosophers find in knowledge are not experimental; and the Fathers of the Church make no mention of them. On the other hand, the soul is not distinguished from its faculties; that is, intellect and will are the soul itself in two distinct actions. So it is the soul which wants to know and which, as intellect, returns to the sense impressions ("phantasma" of the imagination). Since only sense experience gives notice of the individual, it turns out that the soul or intellect intuites the essence of the things directly.

After the condemnations of 1277, Averroism shut itself off without accepting the philosophical and theological discussions of its postulates nor admitting the new physics. While it languished in France and England, it was spreading in Italy in the first half of the 14th century. In Padua, the theses of Siger of Brabant were being insistently repeated. Marsilius of Padua (+1342), with the collaboration of John of Jandun (+1328?), initiated the political version of Averroism. Possibly both authors only wanted to defend, in their work "Defensor pacis", the existence of a lay state as opposed to the temporal power of the ecclesiastics. But the way chosen could hardly be more revealing. Faith and reason are not only distinct things, but they are separated.

Therefore, there are two modes of life, which correspond to the two ends of man. To achieve the natural end, the princes regulate temporal life in conformity with philosophy, and the priests lead men to eternal life in conformity with Revelation. In a certain way both missions complement one another, for religion, in spite of its indemonstrable truths, helps men to behave well in social life. But the two must never be confused and must remain separated. "Defensor pacis" was condemned in 1327 and its authors sought refuge in the court of Emperor Ludwig of Bavaria. Behind this book there was no exclusively political problem, since the rupture between the natural and the supernatural which they advocated will spread through Italy in the first half of the 17th century as the banner of radical religious incredulity.

5. Speculative Mysticism

In the 12th century, mystical literature had become more speculative and had preferred Plato and Neo-Platonism as its philosophical substrate. Meister Eckhart (1260-1327) was the master of numerous spiritual authors. Born in Germany, he was a Dominican and taught in Cologne until he died. In explaining the communication and union of the soul with God, he prescinds from the official doctrine of the Order. He interprets St. Thomas and St. Albert according to the doctrine of Proclus. His fundamental thesis is that God doesn't know Himself because He is, but He is because He knows Himself. From the Neo-Platonic trilogy "esse", "vivere", "intelligere", Eckhart chooses the last as basis of the other two. He justifies this by saying that "esse" befits creatures and is in God only as cause. The words of Exodus, "Ego sum qui sum", don't refer to God as ESSE but rather it is a divine way of eluding an answer or else a way of affirming that God is beyond being. In this way he implied that thought is above being.

For this reason, the idealists will refer to him as a distant predecessor. For him God the Father is "Intelligere", the Son is "Vivere", the Holy Spirit, "Esse". At the end of his life it seems that he subordinated "Intelligere" to "Unum" in order to affirm that the divine Essence is Unity. He says that unity is the exclusive property of the intellect and so spiritual creatures are not completely one because they are beings that have, but are not, "intelligere". From this point of view, creatures are a nullity, for they are only in so far as they participate in the intellect, which is a spark of the Divine Intellect. A study of the human soul verifies that there is a residue which contains "something uncreated and uncreatable, which is the intellect", in which man is not distinct from God, because "the Father begets me His son and His own Son. Everything that God does is one." The nearness to pantheism is evident. These and other propositions of Eckhart were condemned by the Church. But his influence felt in his disciples John Tauler (1300-1361), Blessed Henry Suso (1295-1366) and John Ruysbroeck (1293-1381), all spiritual writers.

6. Concluding Views

John Gerson (+1429), chancellor of the U. of Paris from 1395, complained that the masters did not keep to their own subjects. From this, he begins a critique of speculative Scholastic theology whose arguments will permeate the 14th and 15th centuries. He points out that men think they are theologians if they have only learned philosophy, as well as similar ideas. For him the cause of all these evils is, on the one hand, the treating of metaphysics as logic, and on the other hand, pride in trying to demonstrate those things which depend exclusively on God's free Will, such as creation. He says that this erroneous attitude comes from the Neo-Platonic naturalism of the Arabs which led Christian thinkers to introduce in God distinctions "ex natura rei" or as Duns Scotus says, "formalitates", which are similar to real distinctions.

Arab Neo-Platonism has led to an exaggerated realism of the ideas, which makes of God a being according to the measure of thought, which destroys the simple and free God of faith. Gerson detects well the error of radical Platonism when he affirms that the realism that must be avoided consists in believing that everything that man knows in a universal mode exists separately in things and in God, because this means transforming logic (the universal concept) into metaphysics and later into theology. By this road a general confusion has been created in the orders of knowledge which is responsible for many heresies. As a result of this critique, Gerson tends toward nominalist theses which seem to him, as theologian, to prevent these dogmatic errors. He also reminds his contemporaries that they must dominate the daughters of pride: vain curiosity, desire for singularity and the aggravated "esprit de corps" of the diverse tendencies, which make scarce and render difficult the peaceful possession of true Christian wisdom. For this he proposes as models the great masters of the 13th century, especially St. Bonaventure.

Thus, at the end of the 14th century we are present at the decadence of Scholastic philosophy. Certainly the principal doctrinal tendencies are preserved, but without sufficient internal force to hinder nominalist havoc. On the other hand, the University of Paris finds itself involved in the struggles between the Papacy and France and little by little ceases to be the University of Christianity, in order to be reduced to a national phenomenon, above all from the time of the Western Schism (1379-1418).

Only with the danger of the Protestant pseudo-reform, connected with nominalism, will the Christian spiritual forces be reunited and will give rise to a rebirth of Scholastic philosophy, which will render great service in the Council of Trent.